



The Manasseh Hill Country Survey

*- Volume 3 -
From Nahal 'Iron to
Nahal Schechem*

Adam Zertal
and Nivi Mirkam

The Manasseh Hill Country Survey

Culture and History of the Ancient Near East

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The Manasseh Hill Country Survey

Volume III: From Nahal 'Iron to Nahal Shechem

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Edited by

Shay Bar



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Library of Congress Control Number: 2015956662

Typeface for the Latin, Greek, and Cyrillic scripts: "Brill". See and download: brill.com/brill-typeface.

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ISSN 1566-2055

ISBN 978-90-04-31229-6 (hardback)

ISBN 978-90-04-31230-2 (e-book)

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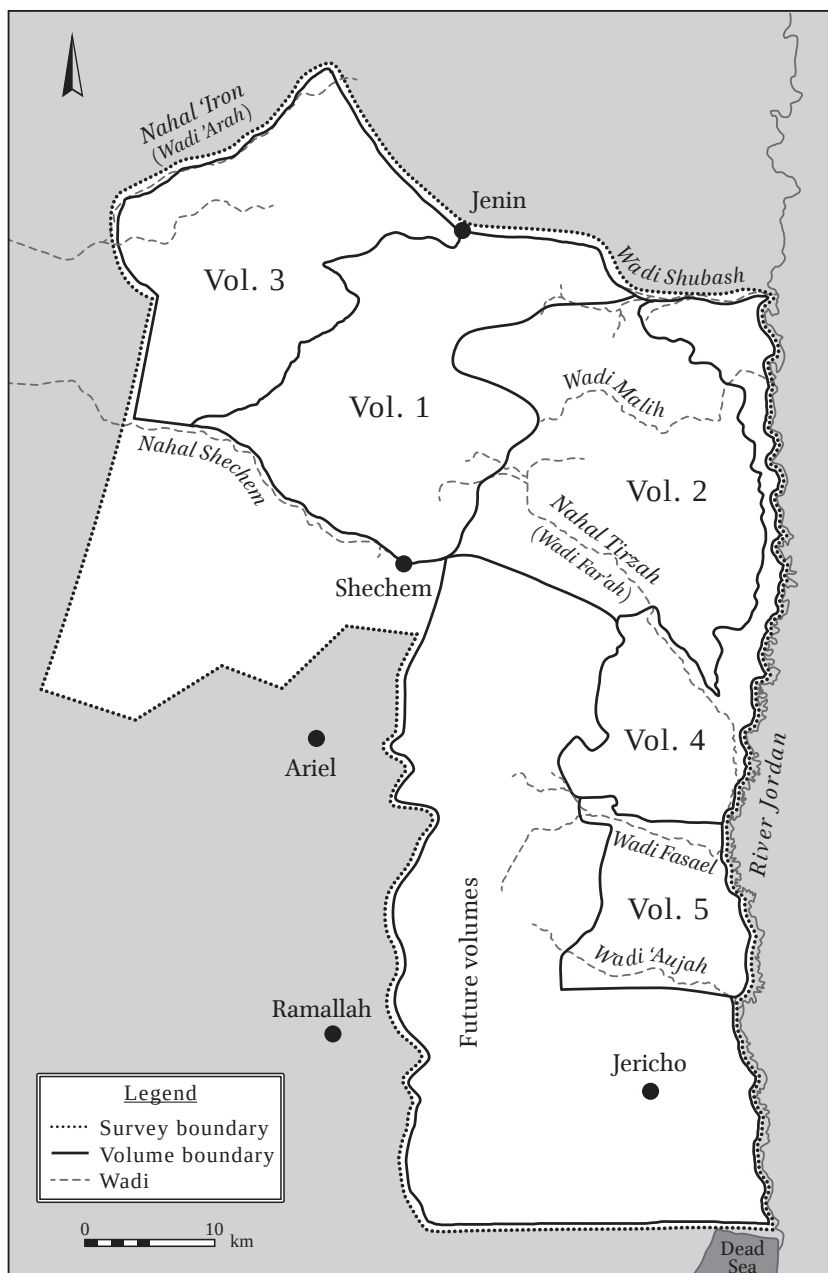
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1. The Manasseh Hill Country Survey, Volumes of publication.

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ABBREVIATIONS

a.s.a. - above surrounding area	lt - light
a.s.l. - above sea level	LU - landscape unit/s
BCE, B. C. E. - Before Common Era	m - metre, metres
blk - black	MA - Middle Ages, Medieval period
brn - brown	Mam – Mamluk
b.s.a - below surrounding area	MB - Middle Bronze Age
Byz - Byzantine period	misc - miscellaneous
CE, C. E. - Common Era	mod - modern
Chal - Chalcolithic period	No., nos - number, numbers
cp - cooking pot	Ott - Ottoman period
cu. m - cubic metre	PEF - Palestine Exploration Fund
dec - decorated, decoration	Pers - Persian period
dk - dark	pk - pink
EA - el-Amarna	rd - red
EB - Early Bronze Age	Rom - Roman
EM - Early Moslem period	sq. km - square kilometres
EP, E. P. - Elevation point	sq. m - square metres
ER - Early Roman period	SWP - Survey of Western Palestine
gr - grey	wh - white
ha - hectare	yel - yellow
Hel - Hellenistic period	Gen - Genesis
HM - holemouth (jar)	Josh - Joshua
IA - Iron Age	Jdt - Judith
Kh. - Khirbeh, Khirbet	Judg - Judges
km - kilometre	Kgs - Kings
LB - Late Bronze Age	Macc - Maccabees
LR - Late Roman period	Tal. - Talmud

PREFACE

This book, Volume 3 of the Manasseh Hill-country Survey, continues and completes the coverage of territories published as Volumes 1 and 2. As suggested in Volume 1 (The Shechem Syncline – Zertal 1992; 2004), the purpose of the project is to fully survey the area from the Valley of Jezreel to the Dead Sea, and from the River Jordan to the Mediterranean coast, on foot. This volume presents the results of the survey of the north-western corner of the Manassite allotment, together with Volumes 1 and 2 (The Eastern Valleys and the Fringes of the Desert – see Zertal 2008 and Map 1), now covering a contiguous strip of land.

The survey project began in 1978, not far from the area of Volume 3, in the Dothan Valley. Since then, efforts have been made to improve the results, revisit some of the sites, and add plans and photographs. In addition, all the excavation results conducted by others in the relevant territory since our publication of the Hebrew version (1992) have been included in this volume.

Before commencing our work, the area covered by Volume 3 was practically a *tabula rasa*. This important region in the heartland of the Holy Land was unexplored and unknown, and even the famous 'Arunah pass (Nahal 'Iron), the arena of Thutmoses III's first campaign, had never been explored on foot. Thus the survey has yielded new information and many new sites, which have enriched, and perhaps modified, our knowledge of the area. Another example is Kh. el-Ḥamam (Arubboth-Narbatah, Site 146), the discovery of which has solved the much-discussed geographical-historical problem of the Solomonic Districts (I Kgs 4) and the location of the city of Arubboth (see Albright 1925; Maisler 1933; Wright 1967; Zertal 1982; 1984; 1993a). It has also added a previously unknown Roman siege-system at the site (Zertal 1995), dated to the Great Revolt against Rome (66 CE).

Two other discoveries are noted in this volume, among others. The first relates to the book of Judith of the Apocrypha, dated to the Persian period (see Grintz 1957; Moore 1985; Meeks 1993; Zertal 2009). Its geography seems now to have been clarified following the survey. Another discovery is el-Aḥwat (Site 28), where a previously unknown well-fortified city of the 13th–12th centuries BCE has been explored and excavated (Zertal 2010; 2012). The results point to a possible foreign ethnic group (Shardana from Sardinia?) which settled in the place, possibly under Egyptian rule. Biblically speaking, it may be connected to the events in the Book of Judges

4-5, hence solving another geographical-historical question: the location of Haroshet ha-Goyim and the geography of the battle of Deborah.

The general methodology of the survey has not been changed or altered much from the principles set out in Volume 1 (Zertal 2004): a thorough foot-survey, division into landscape-units, categorizing of the site components into various natural and environmental characteristics, and wide-ranging documentation, comprising analyses, statistics and illustrations.

Another addition in this volume is the more detailed historical-ethnographic material from sources prior to the technological reform of the 20th century. The site descriptions of prominent early scholars (Robinson, Guérin, the British Survey, Abel) have been included, together with the ancient, pre-medieval and medieval sources (Bible and Mishna, Roman and Byzantine, Early Moslem sources, etc.). Much historical information on Arab villages, quite numerous in this area, is included. Most of this information was added from the Medieval and Ottoman period sources (see Tcheleby 1640; Volney 1783-1784; Beyer 1936; 1940; Heid 1960; Yekutieli 1971; Hutteroth and Abdulfatah 1977; Meron and Kabha 1993; etc.)

The late Nivi Mirkam was among the founders of the project, and took part in the survey between 1978 and 2000, when a serious illness prevented his participation. He passed away on 15 Jan 2004, aged 63. Nivi contributed much, not only to the survey itself, but also to the extensive discussions. This gave rise to the decision to make him a co-author of Volume 3.

The Manasseh Survey owes everything to its loyal, enthusiastic and interested team. It consists of students and volunteers, young and less young, academics and non-academics, of all ages and sexes. At most times we are a group of 10–15 persons, who have left their homes and occupations and set out every Friday morning for the last 37 years, sharing the hard work and the discoveries.

Among the first group of the survey were the late Nivi Mirkam, Shraga Hashman, Idan Shaked (1986-1989), Liah Tramer (1987-1990 and from 2010 onwards), Yasmin Bar-Maor (1988-1990), Adi Ziv-Asudri (1990-1993), Yoni Rand (1988-1990), Zach Horowitz (1990-1993), Einat Goldfarb (1993-1995), Haim Cohen and Dror Ben-Yosef (1993-1995 and 2000-2009), Natalie Masika (1989-1991), Nirit Lavie-Alon (1993-1996) and Rafi Kimchi (1994-1996). Ron Be'eri, Arad Haggi and Murad Tabar participated between 1997 and 2005. The present team (2005 and on) includes Dr. Shay Bar, Amatsia Halevi, Dr. Yizhak Bejerano, Shoshi and Meir Adar, Osnat Gadir, Oren Cohen, Liah Tramer, Shraga Hashman, and Moshe Einav.

General assistance to the project is given by Kibbutz Ein-Shemer and

the University of Haifa. Financial support was, and still is, given by the Norwegian Organization for Israel and the Bible (Seamen's Church), headed by Gro and Bruno Wenske; the ASEO and Pedagogica Foundations, represented by Abraham Ben-Naftali; the Hecht Foundation; the Manasseh Regional Council; the Municipality of Tal 'Iron, which assisted in the excavations of el-Aḥwat; the Shomron Regional Council, which helped in aerial photography and mapping; and the Ben-Dor Company, which donated funds. Special thanks are due to Shuki Lewin and the late Gilad Zar for their help.

This volume was translated by Amatsia Halevi and Ruth Ben-Mayor, and the English version was edited by John Tresman. Sapir Haad was in charge of the graphic design and Oren Cohen proof-read the text. The overall organization of the English version was made by Dr. Shay Bar.

Many new additions and changes have entered the new English Volume 3:

1. Most of the site descriptions have been rewritten, due to the addition of information and later excavations;
2. All the lists and indices (sites, springs, place names etc.) have been up-dated;
3. New appendixes have been added;
4. The pottery plates have been re-edited, with better coordination between the textual descriptions and the plates;

Most of the additions described, if not all, are thanks to the editor, Dr. Shay Bar, who has invested much effort in producing the volume.

Adam Zertal, May 2015

PART ONE
INTRODUCTION

CHAPTER ONE

GEOGRAPHICAL AND SETTLEMENT DATA

A. HISTORY OF RESEARCH AND HISTORICAL SOURCES

The history of the research of the region is similar to that published in Volume 1 (The Shechem Syncline; Zertal 2004). Like the latter, a very small part of the area referred to in this Volume, close to the Dothan Valley and Wadi 'Arah, was visited by travellers and explorers in the past. Most of it was not of much interest to visitors, tourists, or pilgrims. The reasons for this were mentioned in the previous volumes: there were no holy sites, nor places of worship, nor important cities in this area. In addition, the approach to the region and movement within it was difficult. Parts of the territory were remote and covered with a tangled thicket of vegetation, difficult to penetrate. The risks and insecurity were also a deterrent factor to the explorer.

A number of travellers and some sources tell us about the town of Jenin (previous names: Gina, Beth-Hagan, Ginay, Le Grand Gerin), an important village situated on the road from Samaria to the Jezreel Valley. Ta'anach, not far away, was described several times thanks to its Biblical importance. However, the north-western part of the region (the hills of Ya'bad) and the southwestern one (the Narbatah region and the district of Bal'ah) were barely acknowledged, together with the fringes bordering the Sharon and the *Via Maris*.

The Crusader and other Medieval sources, which dealt mainly with the district of Caesarea, were gathered by Rohricht (1887), Gildenmeister (1881; 1883; 1884; 1885) and Beyer (1936; 1940). Rohricht also recorded Moslem traditions in the area between Zebabdeh in the east and 'Attil in the west, for which there are hardly any other sources.

In the Egyptian sources – the el-Amarna letters of the Late Bronze Age – the cities Socoh, Yehem, Hibzan, Gath, Burin, Zephath, and 'Arunah appear along the *Via Maris*, with several hinterland sites – Gina, Gintir-immunima, Ginati'ashna, and Nuribdah. The Bible mentions Beth-Hagan (today's Jenin), Ta'anach, Aniam (?), Gath-Rimmon, Arubboth, and Socoh. The Book of Judith mentions Ta'anach, Dothan, Bethuliya, Shalem, and Bethomestaim (Beth-Homotaim). Josephus mentions only Ginai and Narbatah. In the Onomasticon of Eusebius there are eleven references – Beth-Hinay (twice), Beth-Hagan, Beth-'Eqed, Gath-Rimmon (twice),

Ta'anach (twice), Shalem, and Socoh. The *Talmud* mentions Kfar-Parshai, Barqatah, Ginai, Rimmon, and Beth-Hinay. In the Medieval sources, the region appears almost only with reference to Caesarea. In the list of estates donated by Sultan Baibars to his followers in 1265, after the victory over the Crusaders, 23 settlements are mentioned, most of which are in the surveyed region. In the Ottoman census of 1596 most of the Arab villages are mentioned. The Damascus–Cairo mail road, passing via Jenin, appears several times.

As for modern explorers, Robinson (1970: 122–125) toured the villages of the region between 1837 and 1852. He first went from Nablus to Jenin, then from Lajjun to Umm el-Faḥm, and then to Ya'bad, 'Attil, and Rammin. The reason for this peculiar route is not clear – was it a survey or just a trip?

The French explorer Guérin (1870) went from Jenin to Kh. Bel'ameh, Qabatiyeh, er-Rammeh, 'Arrabeh, el-Yamun, and Umm el-Faḥm. Then he travelled southwards back along the Sharon road. All in all, he visited less than 10% of the villages. Guérin's contribution was above all in his geographical–historical approach, resulting in several site identifications and suggestions. He was the first to relate to the Book of Judith as a historical document, identifying some of its places (a good identification of Shalem as the village of Salem, and probably an incorrect one of the city of Bethuliya as the village of Sanur).

The first to provide a relatively comprehensive and thorough description of the territory were the members of the British Survey of Western Palestine (SWP 1872–1877), who for the first time surveyed all the villages. Their ethnographic and economic data (description of the villages, their sizes, springs, olive orchards, etc.), is still valuable material for comparison.

However, these surveyors learned more from verbal information from the local *fellahin* than from a strict survey. The British surveyors mainly explored the Biblical tells, such as Ta'anach and Megiddo, and the Roman sites with architecture above the surface. In their publications there are relatively good descriptions of some sites: Kh. Ibn 'Amr, Kh. Massin, Kh. Birein, Kh. Beidus, and Umm Riḥan, but many other sites were not found, among them the important tell sites of 'Abeideh, Tell esh-Sheikh Ṣabar, Kh. Mas'ud, Kh. 'Aqqabeh, Abu Rujman, el-Aḥwat, Ferasin, Kh. Ḥamam, and others.

From 1880 to 1967, the region was completely ignored, and the lack of evidence regarding Wadi 'Arah, which was among the more important routes in ancient times, is rather surprising. In the vicinity of Shechem, for example, two surveys and several excavations (Shechem-Ballatah,

Samaria-Sebastiyeh, and Tel Far'ah-Tirza), were conducted at the same time.

In the Israeli Emergency Survey (Gophna and Porath 1972), only 18 sites, fewer than 10% of the total number presented in this Volume, were explored. In addition to these, eight more sites were inspected by Porath (1968). Even then, the large Narbatah region, for example, remained virtually unexplored.

Contrary to the shortage of archaeological information, the region produced a number of historical articles. Many scholars dealt with Thutmosis III's lists and the Battle of Megiddo. Others used various Egyptian topographical records (Amenhotep II, Ramses II, Shishak), and material derived from the el-Amarna letters. The Bible was also used, mostly without information from the field.

Despite all these activities, the territory remained relatively unexplored. It is hoped that the new information presented here will encourage fresh interest and deeper research.

B. THE GEOGRAPHY OF NORTH-WESTERN MANASSEH

1. *Boundaries*

The area is mostly enclosed by natural boundaries:

The north-western border is the channel of Wadi 'Arah, along the geological fault between the Sennonian and Cenomanian-Turonian areas. Whether the natural boundary is identical to the historical one is uncertain, as its definition in the Bible is vague: Manasseh's borders with Issachar and Asher are not clearly defined (Kallai 1967: 146–151).

Direct and indirect considerations, related to Roman-Byzantine sources, led us to accept Wadi 'Arah as the border. This is supported by Josephus, who adds that the Carmel ridge in the region of Akko belonged to the Phoenicians (War III, iii,1). Josephus also noted that the latter was within the territory of Issachar. A Byzantine source, *Notitia Duxpatrius*, dated to the 5th century CE, defines the Carmel as Manassite, and Wadi 'Arah as "The wide stream separating Sebastiyeh and Caesarea" (Safrai 1980: 44).

The western boundary is both natural and historical. It is simply the line between the foothills of Manasseh and the alluvial plain of the Sharon (Karmon 1959). However, this line is not definite; penetrating into the hills are small valleys and enclaves of arable alluvial soil, mainly in the stream outlets (Inbar and Tsoar 1996). The line here is not straight, but for our purpose, we considered it so. Along this line passes the important *Via Maris* (for details see Aharoni 1979: 45–54).

The north-eastern boundary passes between the Jezreel Valley floodplain and the low ridges of the Umm el-Faḥm anticline – from Jenin to Ta'anach and Megiddo. This boundary is both morphological and historical. The northern ridges of the Shechem syncline enter here into the alluvial plain of the Jezreel Valley. The historical boundary is mentioned three times: in the Israelite settlement period it separated Manasseh's territory from the Canaanite cities in the valley (Josh 17, 11-14); during the United Monarchy it separated the Solomonic Third and Fifth Districts (I Kgs, 4, 7-10); and during the Roman period it was the boundary between Samaria and the Galilee (War III: Ch.4). Along this boundary passed the branch (A₂) of the *Via Maris*, the northern extension of the road from Hebron via Shechem to the Jezreel Valley (road B4-6 in our terminology).

The southern boundary is referred to in the territory of Volume 2 (Zertal 2008a). Here there is a distinction (as in Volume 1; Zertal 2004) between

the Shechem syncline and north-west Manasseh. This boundary is therefore defined as follows: In the south-west the boundary passes along Nahal Shechem from its source towards the Sharon plain (north of Tulkarm), reaching the road to Bal'ah. From here it continues eastwards, along the watershed line of the Bal'ah ridge until Wadi Massin, where it emerges from Wadi er-Rammeh. Then it runs along road B4 to the Dothan Valley and Jenin. The southern boundary complements the western Shechem syncline.

2. Geology and Geomorphology

This Volume covers the western part of the Shechem Syncline. Its morphology is mainly dictated by the 'Anabtah anticline in the south and the Umm el-Faḥm anticline in the north. Both anticlines are made of hard Cenomanian-Turonian limestone and dolomites (with several additions), and both are parallel to the main syncline (Meimaran 1980: 223). The Shechem syncline and the anticlines around it were fractured and faulted during the formation of *grabens* and *horsts*. Intensive erosion formed the inner valleys, which were much more suitable for human habitation.

Of the four strips of the Shechem syncline, it is the western one (western Samaria) which is the subject of this Volume. This strip is roughly 28 km long and 15–17 km wide; about 420 sq. km in area. Geologically, the Senonian *Menuha* and *Meshash* formations occur here on top of chalky Cenomanian-Turonian ones.

The area is built of long hilly ranges, oriented east-west, descending westwards to the Sharon Plain. This system was created during the Neogene, when a series of active faults occurred in the hard chalk in the east. The erosion process deepened the streams along the seams between the soft and the hard limestones. The main streams crossing north-west Manasseh are listed in Table 1:

Name	Length (km)	Direction of flow	Geology
'Iron	14	NE–SW	Eocene – CT seam
'Assal	12	E–W	Senonian–CT seam
Jiz	17	E–W	Senonian–CT seam
Massin	16	E–W	Eocene – CT seam
Shechem	20	SE–NW	Senonian–CT seam

Table 1: Main Wadis of North-West Manasseh (from north to south).

As for rocks, the region is diverse. Its basis is hard limestone and dolomite, on top of which are Senonian from the centre of the syncline and Eocene from the Sharon. They are of marine origin (Judah group), and include sporadic *huwwar* layers. The landscape is of boulders up to 1 m high, while the *huwwar* areas appear as natural terraces. A thick crust of *nari* has been formed on the rocks of the Judah group, which when eroded in the moist climate, becomes *terra rossa* soil. This group is present mainly in north-west Manasseh and the hills of Ta'anach and Ya'bad. At the edges of this group the *Mount Scopus* group is noticeable, containing soft chalk and *huwwar*. It extends along Nahal 'Iron, Wadi Massin, and the area of Baqa el-Gharbiyeh. It also appears south of the fault line between the hills of Umm el-Faḥm and Ya'bad, in the Narbatah area, and north of Wadi er-Rammeh. The *Avdat* group occurs north of Nahal 'Iron, south and east of the Dothan Valley, south of Wadi Massin, and in the Bal'ah plateau.

Morphology: The two anticlines – 'Anabtah and Umm el-Faḥm – were probably one anticline in the past, paralleling that of the Far'ah anticline. If this assumption is correct, then it seems that the rock at the top of the ancient anticline was eroded away, exposing the Cenomanian-Turonian base. A possible proof is the intrusions of younger Cenomanian-Turonian rocks, remnants of the ancient anticline. It seems therefore, that the high mountainous ridge was a part of the 'Anabtah anticline, sectioned by faults.

The segmented anticlinal structure of north-western Manasseh created a system of axes oriented east-west. This is how the historical routes were formed, some passing on top of ridges and watersheds (Road A3), and some inside and along the wadi beds (Nahal 'Iron road – A1).

3. Climate, soil, water and vegetation

The climate is typically Mediterranean. Its characteristics are presented in Volume 1 (Zertal 2004: 26). It has a prolonged hot summer, with temperatures fluctuating considerably between day and night, and with an average of 40% cloud overcast. Solar radiation is strong in summer and moderate in winter. The average yearly rainfall is 600 mm. The rainfall declines from south to north, following the decrease of elevation of the mountains: for example, the yearly average in Jenin (140 m a.s.l.) is only 480 mm. The stable precipitation allows extensive dry agriculture, with horticulture (mainly olives), wheat, barley, and summer crops (vegetables, watermelons, etc.). The relative humidity is lower than in the coastal plain,

resulting in less dew, and very dry heat-waves (Arabic: *hamsin*; Hebrew: *sharav*) developing in spring and autumn. In summer, the prevailing wind is westerly both day and night. During the winter it is less frequent and less constant, due to variations in the barometric systems.

The soils, typical of the hilly Mediterranean region (Zertal 2004: 26–27), were formed by erosion of carbonate rocks: chalk, dolomite, *huwwar*, and *nari*. The main soils are *terra rossa*, brown Mediterranean forest soil, and *rendzina*. In the inner valleys and wadis the dominant soil is *alluvium*, containing pebbles.

Terra rossa is a hilly red or red-brown superficial soil, the product of eroded solid chalk, mostly under vegetation cover. Its texture is clayish and it is well drained. A large mass of *terra rossa* occurs on the Bal'ah ridge between Jebel 'Ilan in the east and Shuweikeh in the west, and between Wadi Massin in the north and Nahal Shechem (Wadi She'ir) in the south. Another concentration occurs between er-Rammeh and Şaidah, and a third stretches from Wadi Jiz to Nahal 'Iron (the Narbatah region and the hills of Ya'bad). *Terra rossa*, most suitable for orchards, covers more than 60% of the area.

Brown Mediterranean forest soil contains eroded products of semi-hard chalky rocks, *nari* or chalky conglomerate, created under rich vegetation. It represents 10% of the area, and occurs in two masses: a major one in the area of 'Arrabeh–Fahmeh–Şaidah (Narbatah region), and another in the el-Yamun – Silet el-Khartiyeh territory (Jezreel fringes). The brown Mediterranean soil is a mixture of *terra rossa* and *rendzina* suitable for horticulture and field crops.

Rendzina is a grey or brown-grey soil, a product of soft chalk or *huwwar* in a Mediterranean climate. It is superficial, devoid of specific structure, and poor in organic matter. Dense low vegetation grows in the *rendzina* areas. Around them there is generally a combination of different soils, rich in water sources. The landscape has gentle rounded slopes and numerous natural terraces. A large mass of *rendzina* occurs in the 'Ajjeḥ-'Arrabeh-Fahmeh district.

Alluvial soils are brown or black, with flaky or nut-like texture, moderate drainage qualities, and an organic material content. They are found in the inner valleys, and are common along wadis and small valleys. Tells, or sites whose inhabitants cultivated the soil, developed nearby. Examples are the 'Ar'arah valley, various areas along Wadi 'Assal, the Mughraqah valley (near Kh. el-Ḥamam), and the 'Ibthan valley.

Water sources are mainly springs and *nab'ahs*, and the collection of

rain-water in cisterns was also common. There is no perennial stream in the region. Water may have flowed in ancient times in Nahal Shechem.

A layer spring occurs when a horizon of underground water in a stratigraphic column of sedimentary rocks is exposed (Shatner 1970: 58). Then an outlet for the water is formed from a permeable horizon (*aquifer*) or rock on top of an impermeable horizon (*aquiclude*) of soft Senonian rock. The rate of flow of such springs depends on the rock composition, the inclination of the layers, and the size and capacity of the reservoir. Due to the scarcity of the local reservoirs there are no significant springs in the western part of Manasseh.

A *nab'ah* is a spring reachable by digging or tunnelling. It is formed when the drainage basin supplies small quantities of water, unable to break through to the surface without human intervention.

Most of the springs and *nab'ahs* in the area belong to the western water strip between Nahal Shechem in the south and Tell Ta'anach in the north (for details see Zertal 1988: 53–54; 2004: 28). Along Wadi Ḥasan is a group of flowing springs (Ḥajjeh, Ḥanuni, Bir el-Gharbi, Bir es-Sebba, and others). Their associated sites are scattered along the fringes of the Jezreel Valley.

The four springs of Faḥmeh and that of Şaidah (Bir es-Siflani) are situated on the Faḥmeh–Şaidah ridge, in the centre of the Narbatah district.



2. Flood in Wadi Jiz, 1982. Floods in Samaria's streams occur in very rainy years.

The large Tell Wadi el-Bir (site 164) is located next to Bir es-Siflani.

An additional group lies along Nahal 'Iron. The geological structure creates many springs, most of them in the vicinity of 'Ar'arah, with four springs (Sammal, Zaituneh, Balad, and Haniyah), and some 15 more along the wadi, including 'Ein Ibrahim, Zeituneh, Dalyah, and Sliman. The Sheikh Iskander mass is also rich in low-capacity springs, including Iskander, 'Anin, Zeituneh, Amihai, and Sapir. The Barta'ah spring is an exception, flowing from the hilly region south of Nahal 'Iron.

The last group is situated in the western border of the region, along the line between the hill country and the Sharon plain: It includes the exceptionally rich Assawir springs, and Isiyar, Bedusseh, and Burin near Baqa el-Gharbiyeh, and Jatt and 'Ibthan.



3. *Fellahin* women carry water jars from the spring to the village. Photo from Preiss and Rohrbach 1925: 214.

The linkage between settlement and water sources will be discussed separately with each landscape unit.

Vegetation: Here, as in other cultivated hilly areas, only small areas of the original vegetation have survived. The natural flora was displaced as agricultural cultivation progressed. In general, the vegetation here is similar to that in the Shechem syncline, the result of climatic, geological, terrain, and soil conditions.

The remaining natural vegetation is important for the study of ancient societies. Zohary (1980: 186–190) counts five vegetal societies: thicket (*maquis*), wood or forest, park-forest, scrubland (*garigue*), and undergrowth (*batha*). The distribution of the vegetation is basically dependent



4. Spring spouting head. Water was supplied to the villages by collecting the flow at the source. Photo from Preiss and Rohrbach 1925: 116.

on altitude, soil, and geology.

The Mediterranean thicket is the dominant vegetal coverage. It consists mainly of short evergreen trees and tall shrubs, mostly terebinth (*Pistacia palaestina* Boiss) and common oak (*Quercus calliprinos* Webb) which reach a height of 4–5 m.

A valuable example still exists in the Umm Riḥan national park, near modern Qazir. The park is covered with dense, impassable thicket, a hiding place for animals and a source of wood for building and fuel. Remnants of the thicket survive in the remote corners of the region: between 'Illar and Kafr R'ay, north of Wadi Massin, and in the Umm Tut area. The climbing and creeper plants, found also in the Senonian plateaus and the *rendzina* areas, are evidence of its past, as in the Faḥmeh–Kafr Ra'y–Şaidah area. The region is devoid of proper forest vegetal societies.

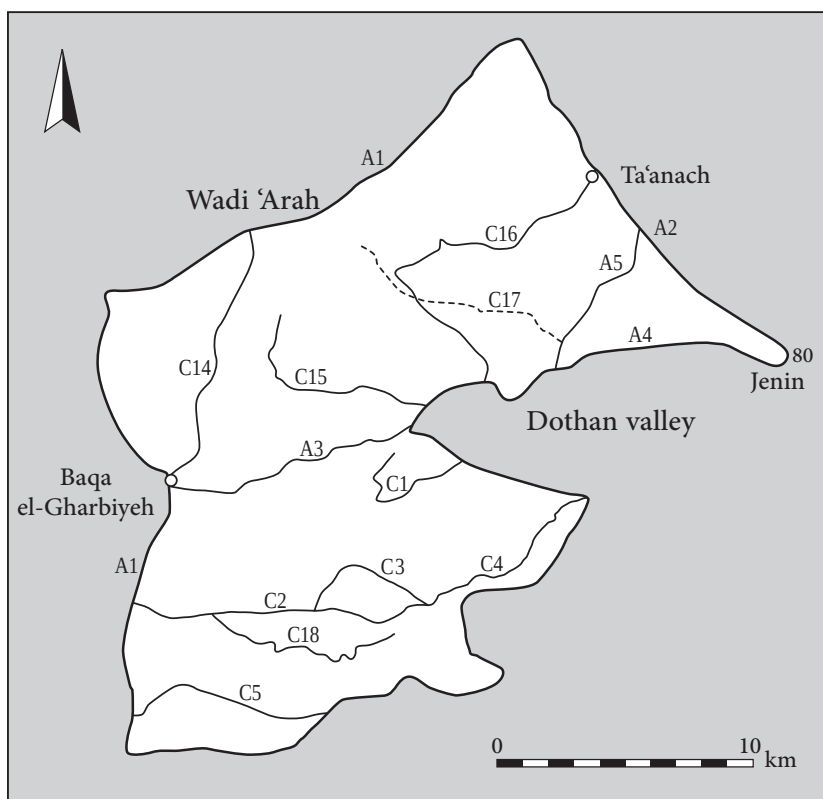
A park-forest is typical of the western belt in the meeting of the hills and the Sharon plain. Here it consists of the common carob (*Ceratonia siliqua*) and pistachio (*Pistacia lentiscus*) (Zohary 1971: 245–246; Waisel et al. 1978: 23–24). The park-forest is good for grazing, but less suitable for cultivation.

There are relatively few areas of *batha* and *garigue*. *Batha*, where the thorny burnet (*Sarcopoterium spinosum*) is almost the sole plant, occurs in the *rendzina* areas of Faḥmeh–Şaidah, most of which became cultivated fields long ago. *Garigues* of secondary growth of soft-hairy calicotome (*Calicotome villosa*) can be found in Nahal 'Iron and its environs. The soft-hairy calicotome competes here with the Mediterranean thicket for the re-conquest of deserted land, which was arable in the past.

4. Roads

The roads and routes are divided into the three customary groups: international, national/regional, and local (Aharoni 1979: 43). In various publications (Zertal 1988: 65–67; 2004: 31–34) it was suggested that the Manasseh hill country was a natural hub between the coast and the Jezreel Valley, between the southern and the northern hills and the Jezreel Valley, and between eastern Jordan and the Mediterranean coast. Consequently, most of the important roads have crossed this area throughout the ages.

The territory discussed is crossed by three main roads: *Via Maris*, and its branches; the road connecting the coast with Jordan; and the longitudinal road, ascending from Beer-Sheba via Hebron and Shechem, with its eastern and western branches. It should be added that after many years of research, the influence of roads upon settlement, and vice-versa, remains unsolved: it can be still asked how roads came into existence, and what



5. Map of the main roads reviewed in this Volume: A – international road;
C – local road.

was the significance of the road in ancient human society.

The information presented here is based on geographical factors (e.g. origin, destination, and terrain), the known Roman roads from historical sources, physical remains of surveyed roads, and the road system published by the SWP.

4.1 Roman roads: These roads have generally followed ancient tracks, with some connecting the towns of the Roman period:

4.1.1. Caesarea – Megiddo (equivalent to our A1). Its remains, including milestones without inscriptions, appear in Thomsen (1917: 69 ff. milestones nos. 233–241), and also in Avi-Yonah's map (Avi-Yonah 1963: map 9).

It is likely that this road was built during the reign of Hadrian. The evidence is the construction of the camp of the Sixth Legion at Legio, next to Megiddo and close to the outlet of Nahal 'Iron. We assume that the

'Iron pass was less important in the Bronze and Iron Ages than the other passes through the hills (Appendix B). Only during the reign of Hadrian did military considerations lead this pass to be rebuilt. A road-station or inn from the Roman period was excavated between Umm el-Faḥm and 'Arunah (today's 'Arah) (Glick 1995). It consists of a rectangular building, a yard surrounded by rooms, and other structures. The site has been dated to between the 1st and 3rd centuries CE.

4.1.2. The Caesarea – Ginai road (A3) is mentioned with no reference in Avi-Yonah (1963: 86). The remains of this road include paved sections between Qaffin and the Dothan Valley, and a milestone near Kh. Samarraḥ (Zertal 1986). This road was not less, and possibly even more, important than A1 in most periods.

4.1.3. The remains of the Narbataḥ road (C1) were found along the Kh. Samarraḥ – Kh. Ḥamam – Dothan Valley route (in Wadi Jiz).

4.1.4. Remains of the road from Kh. Mu'allaqah to Umm Riḥan and the farm in Qaṣr el-Lejjah near Shaqed (C17), first suggested by the Umm Riḥan expedition (Dar et al. 1986: 21–22), have been found. The Roman fortress at Kh. Mu'allaqah (Site 18) is probably related to it. The Roman road discovered near Tell Umm Zeid could have been a continuation of this road.

4.1.5. This road leads westward from the hill country north-south road (C16), via Kh. Turah, Kh. Huljan, el-Muṣṭar, and Zibdeh. Traces of the road were found along the route.

4.1.6. The remains of the road from Caesarea to Sebastiyeh via Zeitah, 'Attil, and Wadi esh-Sham, recorded by Avi-Yonah, have not been found, but in the SWP map it appears as an important road.

4.2 Other roads are classified into three customary categories:

A. International roads

Most famous is the *Via Maris* (Meshel 1967; Rainey 1983; Zertal 2011). The earliest evidence is from the record of the first campaign of Thutmosis III (c. 1485 BCE – ANET: 234-242; see mainly Aharoni 1979: 152-166; Goedicke 2000; Redford 2003; Mizrahi 2005; Zertal 2011). The war council at Yehem (today's Kh. Yemmeh) appears as follows:

"They said in the presence of his majesty: What is it like to go [on] this [road] which becomes so narrow?...Will not horse (have to) go after [horse, and the army] and the people similarly? Will the vanguard of us be fighting while the [rear guard] is waiting here in Aruna, unable to fight? Now two (other) roads are here. One of the roads – Behold, it is

[to the east of] us, so that it comes out at Ta'anach. The other – Behold, it is to the north side of Djefti, and we will come out to the north of Megiddo.” (transl. A. Wilson, ANET: 235).

Since 2000, when the Hebrew version of Volume 3 was published, a few changes in the roads should be mentioned.

A1 – The 'Arunah pass: The branch from Kh. Yemmeh – Jatt– Burin –'Arunah – Megiddo, was little used. We assume now that the main branch passed through Wadi Samantar via modern Barta'ah directly to 'Arunah (modern 'Arah) (Zertal 2011). The other new understanding is that the end of this road passed along the Bu'eineh stream to its outlet into the Jezreel Valley.

The northern branch: The identification of Djefti with Tel Esur (Assawir) was first proposed in a seminar at Tel-Aviv University (Na'aman 1984: 262, note 26). This tell was identified in the past as Biblical Arubboth (I Kgs, 4: 10), a suggestion dropped in light of the new information from the excavation.

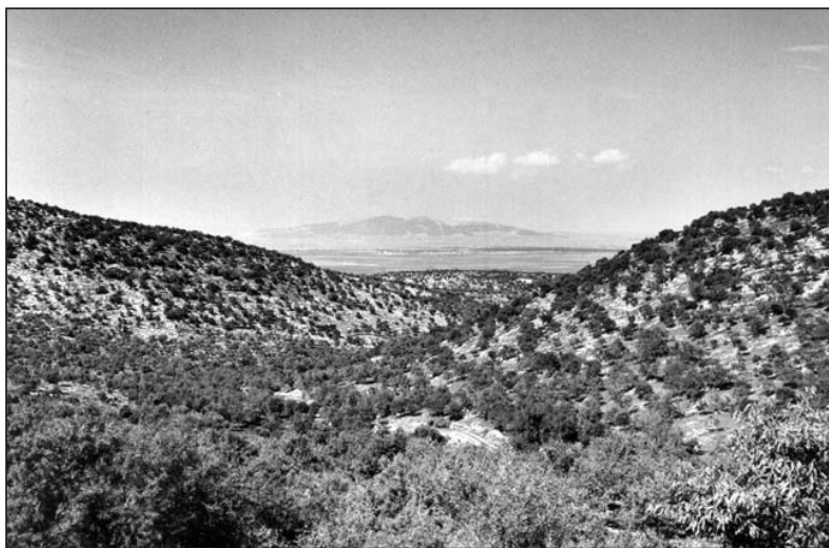
Close to Wadi Samantar are two sites possibly connected to the ancient road: the fortified Iron Age II site in Kh. Mahu (Site 95), overlooking the road at the wadi, and a Roman yard-fort in Kh. Madar (Site 37). In local folklore this branch is called Wadi Marbat, about which Meron and Kabha (1993: 119–120) write: “Wadi el Marbat, which leads from Barta'ah to Baqa el-Gharbiyeh, was in the past a short cut leading from the north of the country to Tulkarm. The marauding gangs took advantage... to ambush passers-by and merchants and to rob their belongings and merchandise”.

A description of the passage through Nahal 'Iron in 1853 appears in the book *Even Sapir* of the Jewish traveller Rabbi Yaaqov Sapir Halevi: “I have been travelling from Haifa to Umm el Faḥm for the last three years on a road on which merchants' caravans bring wheat. There were some five hundred camels and many people and weapons and arms. An Arab approached us with his sword on his hip, his face of a lion, he angrily stopped the donkey at the head of the caravan in front of the camels, and all stopped. And all the men and the camels' owners quaked, and they all gathered and fell at his feet and kissed the fringe of his cloak and begged him: what it is you bear against us? Then he said that someone from Umm el-Faḥm owed him money, and if any of that person's camels are in the caravan, they are to be handed to him and then he will walk away. Then they swore on their lives and the life of their prophet Muhammed that they had nothing belonging to that person and they kissed his beard. Then his anger abated and he returned to his tent. And all the way and the plain were full of black tent dwellers, Kedar/Ismaelites’

tents and flocks and possessions of great wealth" (from Vilnay 1960: 50).

A2, the second branch, stretched northward to Wadi Milkh (Nahal Tut). This branch passed from Tel Esur (Assawir) along the modern Road 6 up to the Elyaqim junction, and then descended to Yoqneam. If Djefti is indeed Tel Esur the identification at Kh. Sit Leila (Aharoni 1958) is incorrect.

A3 was the branch linking Yehem with Ta'anach and Megiddo through the Dothan Valley. It met the national longitudinal road ascending from Hebron to Shechem and Jenin. It ascended from the opening of Jenin north-westward to Tel Ta'anach, met road C16 coming from Y'abad, and ascended to the Megiddo Junction. The historical sources and the finds show that in most periods this branch was the principal connection between the Jezreel Valley and the coastal plain. Its description in the Annals is quite laconic: It commenced "east of us" (meaning, east of Kh. Yemmeh) and emerged into the Valley "near Ta'anach" (ANET: 235). Actually, the route probably started near Baqa el-Gharbiyeh. This convenient road ran along the watershed between Wadis Ghassal in the north and Jiz in the south (see detailed description in Zertal 1986). Neither Thutmosis III nor Amenhotep II mentions the large site at Jatt (probably Gath-Padallah of the el-Amarna letters) in their campaigns. How important was the site at the time we do not know, but very rich Late Bronze Age artifacts have



6. The Burkin Gateway. Through this opening descends road A5, reaching the Jezreel Valley near Ta'anach, 1985.

recently been found there (see discussion in Chapter Four). In Sheet VIII of the SWP map, there is no important path shown from Baqa to the Dothan Valley. Most paths lead from the Qaffin area to Kh. Ferasin and Ya'bad.

In order to understand route A3, the Roman road from Caesarea to Ginei should be followed. Its traces were found along the modern road from Baqa el-Gharbiyeh to the Dothan Valley. The remains were found close to Qaffin Junction, and continued in a straight line to Kh. Samarraḥ, from where it descended to the Dothan Valley, and probably passed along its northern side via Tel Muḥaffar and Bir Ḥasan. Here the road split into two branches: one (A5) descended north-east through Wadi Ḥasan, passed through Kafr Adan, and entered the valley south of Ta'anach. The second branch (A4) continued eastward via Burkin towards Jenin, and joined branch A2.

In our opinion Thutmosis' instructions refer to the branch of Wadi Ḥasan (A5): this might also be "The great pass to Judea", included in the geographical description in the Book of Judith (3:10) (and see Grintz 1957: 97–98). During the settlement boom of the Persian period, Wadi Ḥasan was very extensively used. In addition to its tactical advantages, this pass considerably shortened the way from the Jezreel Valley to the opening of the Dothan Valley. The normal road from Qabatiyeh to Jenin (road B6) passed through a narrow wadi with steep sides, with two large sites opposite each other near Jenin: Ible'am and Kh. en-Najjar (presumably *Gur* of the Bronze and Iron ages – for identifications see Sites 26 and 50 in Zertal 2004). In this place the King of Judah, Ahazia, was ambushed and beaten to death at the order of Yehu (II Kgs, 9, 27).

B. National roads

Only two short stretches of national roads are mentioned here: road B6 leading south-eastwards from Jenin, and a section from the lateral road B1, passing through the western part of Nahal Shechem. The geographical nature of the region forced international and national roads to follow the same routes. To these roads only local roads and paths have been added.

C. Local roads

Ten local roads are included here. Their routes rely upon road descriptions (Roman, Medieval, the SWP map, and local traditions), topography, and information provided by the Manasseh Survey.

C1: The *Narbataḥ* road was a branch of the Roman Caesarea – Ginai road. C1 branched off the main road at Kh. Samarraḥ, and descended in the direction of Wadi Jiz. Then it ascended to Kh. el-Ḥamam, continued

east via Wadi Jiz to the opening of the Dothan Valley, and rejoined the Caesarea – Ginai road. The presumed Roman military camp at el-Mughur (Site 136), south-west of Mevo Dothan, may require moving its route to the top of the Qureinat ridge, instead of through Wadi Jiz. The Narbatah road seems to have been constructed for a single site, and when the place was abandoned its road went out of use.

C2: From Yemmeh to Zawiyeh junction. It leaves A1 near Kh. Yemmeh, and passes 'Attil and 'Illar to Kafr Ra'y, descending towards the Dothan Valley via Faḥmeh, and joins road B4 (Deir Sharaf – Jenin). The paved road from 'Illar to Kafr Ra'y is well known to the locals. This short and convenient route was presented as a good lane in Sheet XI of the PEF map. Lately, an asphalt road has been constructed along it.

During the Mamluk period this road became important, crossing the hills from the Sharon to Jenin. It was described by Evliya Tshelebi, a mid-17th century Turkish traveller, and Volney, who visited it in 1783–4.

Volney (1798–9 in Sezgin 1994: 33–34) describes how ice for cooling (originating at Mt. Hermon), was delivered from Damascus to Cairo. This was customary from the days of Sultan et-Tahr Barquq (1382–1398 CE). Prior to his time the snow was shipped by sea, but in his reign it was dispatched by land using racing camels – *hedjines* (in French - *chameaux coureurs*). In each of the 13 stations along the road were six replacement camels. They left Damascus every other day – a total of 64 shipments from 1 June until 30 November, five camels at a time. The journey lasted 54 hours, with stops at Irbid, Jenin, and Qaqun.

Similar information is available about the Mamluk mail. The postal stations from south to north were: Gaza, Bet-Darras, Lydda, 'Aujah, Tireh, Qaqun, Faḥmeh, and Jenin (Volney 1798–9 in Sezgin 1994: 37–38). This not particularly convenient road shortened the trip, and thus became the main highway.

C3: The 'Illar – Şaidah – Kafr Ra'y road leaves C2 at 'Illar, and turns north over the hills to Şaidah. From there it continues east to Kh. Barquneh and Kh. Umm Kashaf, and back with the C2 at Kafr Ra'y. In fact, the C3 is a by-pass of the C2 road.

C4: The Faḥmeh – Dothan – Qabatiyeh road diverges from C2 to Faḥmeh and 'Arrabeh (along the modern roadway), and then on to the Dothan junction and Qabatiyeh via Wadi Rumman.

C5: Shuweikeh – Silet edh-Dhar. The road passes along the line of Wadi esh-Sham – Bal'ah – Ras Rashin, and over the spine of the hill country to es-Sirtassa (Zertal 2004: site 137).

C14: A branch of A1 from *Baqā el-Gharbiyeh* to 'Arah ('Arunah) via Wadi Samantar.

C15: *Ya'bad* – *Barta'ah*. The road runs along the existing road through Tell 'Abeideh – Zibdeh – esh-Sheikh Şabar – Dhar el-'Abd, and Barta'ah.

C16: *Ya'bad* – 'Anin via the spine of the hills, ascending to the watershed from Ya'bad via Turah el-Gharbiyeh, Nazlet Zeid, Umm Riḥan, and 'Anin. From there it descends north of Nahal Zavdon to join the A2 close to the modern road near Ta'anach.

C17: A Roman road from *Kh. Mu'allaqah* to *Umm Riḥan*, and from there to Jenin (Roman Ginai). Its remains were noticed by the excavators of Umm Riḥan, and appear by the fortress at Kh. Mu'allaqah, and possibly also near the site at Qaşr 'Ein esh- Sheri'ah.

C18: *Wadi Massin road*. It seems that a road for camel caravans, leaving er-Rammeh valley, crossed the hills via Wadi Massin to the A1 near Kh. Yemmeh. Still in use during the British Mandate, it was usable only in summer, and required constant maintenance. In Sheet XI of the SWP map, a path, descending from 'Illar and along Wadi Massin, is marked.

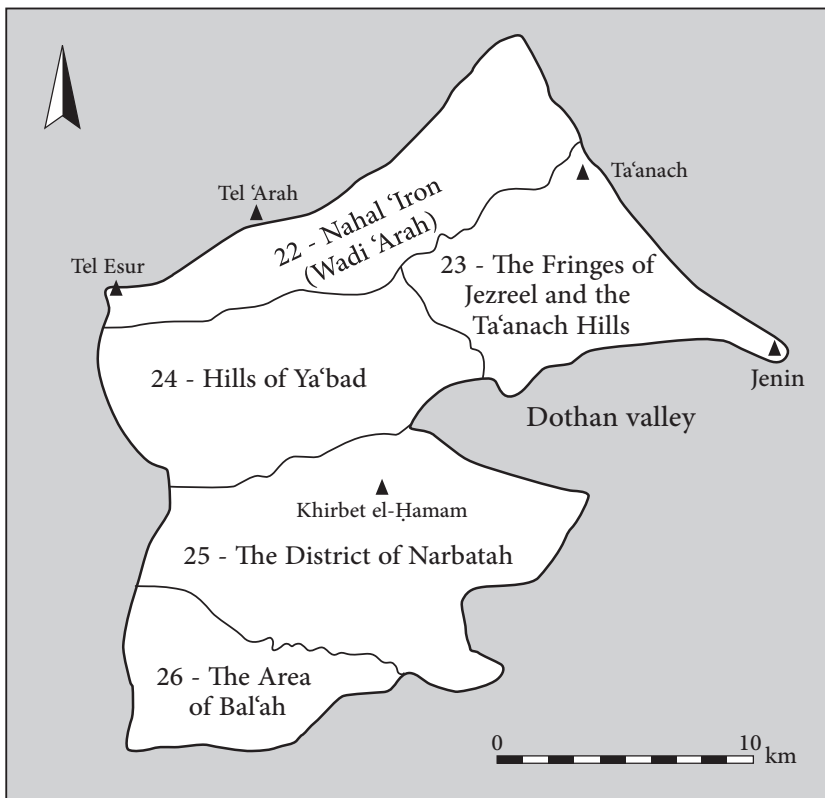
C. LANDSCAPE UNITS

The 420 sq. km described in this Volume have been divided into five landscape units, based on geographical and historical considerations (the division and its principles are discussed in the earlier volumes - Zertal 2004: 13–14; 2008a: 7).

Landscape Unit 22: Nahal 'Iron (Wadi 'Arah)

The unit is roughly 70 sq. km in area, with boundaries determined by the course of Nahal 'Iron. This stream has been widened by erosion, and a pass was formed (Inbar and Tsoar 1996: 280–281). The boundary was delineated south of the Umm el-Faḥm range, thus relating to the active section of the pass. The section north of the stream was not surveyed.

The unit commences in the east with the Rumaneh – 'Anin line, inclusive



7. Landscape units in this volume

of the hills of Salem – Kh. et-Taybeh, and the Amir range (Sheikh Iskander). From 'Anin the boundary goes north to Umm Riḥan, and via Wadi Yaḥmur, Barta'ah and Kh. Madar to the stream south of Kibbutz Barkai. In the north it is now the modern Haderah–'Afula road.

The main geological formation here is the Amir Hills, known also as the Umm el-Faḥm anticline (Sass 1968). It consists mainly of volcanic materials (ash and tufa) with chalk on top. From the summit (Sheikh Iskander, 527 m a.s.l.) the range gradually descends westward (200 m over 7 km) to modern Qazir. Then it drops to the foothills of Umm el-Qutuf – Ma'anit – Metzger. The high barrier of the Umm el-Faḥm anticline overlooks Nahal 'Iron from the south. The few passes crossing the anticline from north to south are accessible only at its fringes in the areas of Salem-Rummaneh in the north-east and in Wadi Samantar in the south-west.

The Nahal 'Iron landscape unit is richer in springs than any other unit. Among the springs, those around the massif of Umm el-Faḥm and Sheikh Iskander are the Umm el-Faḥm, 'Anin, Sheri'ah, and Mu'allaqah springs. Others are on the eastern side – 'Ein Ibrahim, Daliyah, and others, and many in the 'Arah–Ar'arah valley.

The rocks and vegetation of the region are typically Mediterranean. The Sheikh Iskander hill range, however, was rocky and forested in the past, with little arable land. In the western part there are inner valleys with water and good arable land.

Despite the relatively favourable conditions, Nahal 'Iron has only a few large ancient settlements. Along and south of the stream, almost 40 sites have been found, of which only three (Salem, 'Arunah, and Esur) are real tells. The rest are small agricultural settlements, with el-Aḥwat as the only exception. It is significant that even in the Roman period settlements were few, and in the strip south of Nahal 'Iron not a single major tell from the Early Bronze Age has been recorded. There are few Middle Bronze Age, Late Bronze Age, and Iron Age sites in this strip.

The Nahal 'Iron pass is described by Thutmosis III (see above, Roads) and by Hori, the Egyptian messenger from the time of Ramses II (the 'satirical letter' – 13th century BCE): "Behold, the ambushade is in a ravine two thousand cubits deep, filled with boulders and pebbles... The narrow valley is dangerous with Bedouins, hidden under the bushes. Some of them are of four or five cubits (from) their noses to the heel, and fierce of face. Their hearts are not mild, and they do not listen to wheedling. Thou art alone; there is no messenger with thee, no army host behind thee. Thou findest no scout that he might make thee a way of crossing... Thy path is filled with

boulders and pebbles, without a toe hold for passing by, overgrown with reeds, thorns, brambles, and 'wolf's paw.' The ravine is on one side of thee, and the mountain rises on the other. Thou goest on jolting, with thy chariot on its side, afraid to press thy horse (too) hard." (ANET: 477–478).

Aharoni definitely relates the description to Nahal 'Iron, but there are difficulties: There are exaggerations (2000 cubits are approximately 1000 m, while the maximum elevation difference in Nahal 'Iron does not exceed 150 m), typical of the Egyptian sources, and also logical discrepancies. Only in a few places (the descent from Umm el-Faḥm eastwards, and the emergence into the Jezreel Valley at the Qinah stream) is the wadi narrow, and nowhere there are any cliffs or boulders.

The main theme of the description is the lack of habitation. Not a single settlement is mentioned (e.g. 'Arunah and Esur, which existed at the time) along the 20 km of the pass, apart from Megiddo (ANET: 477) and Jaffa, which are not necessarily related to the pass.

During the Early Bronze Age three large sites – 'En Esur (Assawir), 'Arunah and Megiddo – were founded along the pass. 'En Esur was a large settlement, 80 ha in area, discovered and partly excavated by Gophna (1978) and Yannai (1997; 2006). The latter exposed five strata from the Neolithic and Chalcolithic periods, and habitation continued to the Early Bronze Age I. From the Intermediate Bronze Age (also termed Early Bronze Age IV or Middle Bronze Age I) only a single site is known (the cemeteries around Tel Esur, Site 30). Few Middle Bronze Age settlements have been traced in the area, one of which is at the western part, close to the fortified site of Tel Esur (Appendix F). This is a vast cemetery first used in the Chalcolithic period (e.g. Yannai and Horovitz 1998, and see Site 30 for additional references).

During the 2nd and 1st millennia BCE, until Iron Age II, the main settlement was concentrated in the three cities of the pass – Esur, 'Arunah, and Megiddo. A small Middle Bronze Age IIb site was found at Ruġm el-Aḥmar (Site 26), with little presence at Qaṣr 'Ein esh-Sheri'ah (Site 24). No sites from the Late Bronze Age have been found, apart from these tells.

El-Aḥwat (Site 28) is exceptional in being the sole large site dated to the very end of the Late Bronze Age and the beginning of the Iron Age. It differs from other sites by not being a multi-period tell, and was also not a village or small unfortified settlement. It was a fortified town of a new ethnic element, possibly the Shardana of the Egyptian sources. This population settled for a brief period and under special circumstances (Zertal 2012). Apart from the above, nine Iron Age I sites were found.

During Iron Age II the density of settlement did not change (12 sites), and only in the Persian period, when this territory belonged to the flourishing province of Samaria, was there a settlement increase. Pottery from the period was found in 19 sites.

In the Hellenistic period a decrease was registered (12 sites). As usual, the Roman-Byzantine period saw the peak of settlement (21 sites in the Late Roman period and 23 in the Byzantine period). To these periods belong, among others, Qaṣr ‘Ein esh-Sheri’ah (Site 24) and the large site at Umm er-Riḥan (Site 36). A fortress in ‘Ar’arah and villages in Umm el-Faḥm and Barta’ah were recorded in the Crusader period.

Following the Moslem conquest (635 CE) and up to the Middle Ages, most of today’s Arabic villages related to the pass (above all Umm el-Faḥm, ‘Ar’arah, and ‘Arah) were founded. According to the SWP and other sources, these villages of the 19th and beginning of the 20th centuries CE were small hamlets, unlike those of Samaria.

Landscape Unit 23: The fringes of Jezreel and the Ta’anach hills

This 70 sq. km unit lies between the Dothan Valley and Nahal ‘Iron. It is a wide strip of land along the western Jezreel Valley. The boundaries are as follows:

The north-eastern limit stretches between the Jezreel Valley and the low hills of the Umm el-Faḥm and el-‘Asi ranges, north of the Dothan Valley. It follows the old border of the Samarian hills and the valley, both within Manasseh (Josh 17: 11-12). The modern road from Jenin to the Megiddo Junction (A2) follows this route.

The north-western boundary passes along the modern road: Rumaneh – ‘Anin – Kh. Umm Riḥan.

The south-western boundary passes along the watershed roadway (C16) Umm Riḥan – Nazlet Zeid – Ya’bad, the natural line between this landscape unit and Unit 24 – the Hills of Ya’bad.

The south-eastern boundary is identical to the north-western boundary of Volume 1 (Zertal 2004: 81), which passes over the ranges north of the Dothan Valley.

The Jezreel Valley fringes lies between two anticlines, Umm el-Faḥm and el-‘Asi, both influencing the region’s nature. It is an area of low hills between Wadi Zavdon, which is steep and rocky, and Wadi Ḥasan, which offers a shorter road between the Dothan and Jezreel Valleys.

The climate and vegetation are typically Mediterranean. The soil here is brown Mediterranean with some *terra rossa* patches. Cultivation has

replaced natural vegetation. The south and east are rich in water sources and planted with olives, as noted in the SWP. The ranges of Shaqed and Hinanit and the area of Nahal Zavdon are covered with karstic boulders, and there are several springs, including 'Anin and Ḥarubeh.

The sites here are divided as follows:

A. The edges of the Jezreel Valley, with Wadi Ḥasan and the hills of Ta'anach, are the most fertile and the richest in water. Here are the roads of Wadi Ḥasan (A5) and Jenin – Megiddo (A2), which are linked together. Along Wadi Ḥasan are five springs and *nab'ahs*, part of the main water strip (see Zertal 2004: 27–29).

These conditions produced considerable settlement activity during the Bronze, Iron, and Persian periods. The region is slightly hilly and topographically favourable. There are extensive olive groves in the region, and the good conditions already attracted settlement in the Chalcolithic period (Jenin, Bir Ḥanuni, and 'Ein Hajjeh sites). The fortified tells of Jenin and Ta'anach were established during the Early Bronze Age, but otherwise the region remained relatively empty in these periods. From the Intermediate Bronze Age only a single site is known (Kh. Yannun, Site 42), while the Middle Bronze Age II (and especially its later phase) saw a settlement boom. Sherds of this period were found in 13 sites, amongst which are Kh. Yannun and Tell Umm Zeid (Site 53). It seems that the latter was an outpost of the large Tell Ta'anach. Others are small villages, only some of which were fortified.

The Late Bronze Age showed a decrease in population, and only five of the 13 Middle Bronze Age settlements survived. Significant are Kh. Yannun with its rich pottery assemblage, and the fortified Khariqet er-Ras (possibly Gintiashnah of the el-Amarna letters, and see identifications). The situation during the Iron Age I (seven sites) did not change much, possibly due to the dense Canaanite habitation at Ta'anach and other neighbouring places. Unlike the adjacent Dothan Valley, there was no free arable land here, and the land probably belonged to the Canaanite cities (Beth Hagan, 'Tbleam, Ta'anach, and Megiddo). It fits Josh 17: 11–14 exactly, according to which the Israelites were prevented from settling close to the Valley.

However, it was in the Iron Age I that the large tell of el-Batn was founded, developing into a central town during Iron Age II, together with Ta'anach. Sherds from the period were also found at Kh. Ibn 'Amr (Site 54) and el-Hashmiyeh (Site 78). During this period the number of settlements increased to ten, a phenomenon common in the rest of the Samarian territory. The peak of the settlement here occurred in the Persian period (24

settlements), and see further details in Section E.

The sub-region of Nahal Zavdon and the watershed line contain hardly any sites from the Bronze Age periods, but there was a steady increase in the number of sites from Iron Age II to the Roman-Byzantine periods. With the search for arable land, many farms were founded during the period of the Kingdom of Israel (Iron Age II), continuing into the Persian period and afterwards.

Landscape Unit 24: Hills of Ya'bad

The hills of Ya'bad lie between the international road (A1 – west), the *Via Maris* (south – A3), Wadi Yaḥmur, and Wadi Barta'ah (north), and the line Riḥan – Ya'bad (road C16 – east). Its bounds are well defined, with homogeneous characteristics.

The unit is roughly 60 sq. km in area. Its moderate hills are the result of erosion of the longish east-west ranges. Crossing these are four wadi beds oriented north-south: Yaḥmur and Barta'ah, Ḥasffa, 'Arin, and Ghassal, all branches of Nahal Hadera (Inbar and Tsoar 1996). The elevated Umm el-Faḥm anticline also bounds the unit to the north.

Patches of *terra rossa* soil cover the area, scattered mainly among the chalky boulders and in the small valleys. Larger areas of soil cover the watershed plateau and near Zibdeh. The Umm Riḥan Park reserve is a witness to the dense Mediterranean *maquis* in the past. No springs are known, except 'Ein Barta'ah. A few *nab'ahs* exist in the west, in the Kh. Bir el-Isyar (A) – Baqa area.

The 47 sites found are divided into sub-regions:

A. The western section is rich in arable soil and water. Along the roads a chain of tells developed from the Early Bronze Age onwards (Shuweiket er-Ras, Kh. Yemmeh, Jatt, Burin, Esur). The fortified cities thus created continued to the end of the Iron Age, and quite often afterwards.

Smaller sites, mostly established during the Iron Age and later, typify the inner area. In the Chalcolitic-Early Bronze Age periods there are small settlements, such as Metzger, 'Ein Baduseh, and Zeitah (West). The Iron Age saw the foundation of fortified sites, such as Kh. Bir el-Isyar (A), Kh. Naṣur, Kh. Umm edh-Dhiyab, and Kh. Beidus, most of which continued into the Persian period. In the Hellenistic and Roman periods the region flourished because of its closeness to Caesarea and the main road – the *Via Maris*.

B. In the hinterland a relative homogeneous pattern occurred. In the Bronze and Iron Ages this zone was covered by thick *maquis*, with sparse

settlement, in contrast to the abundance of settlement in neighbouring and more easily cultivated areas (the Dothan Valley and next to the roads). Exceptional are two large Middle Bronze Age II sites: Abu Rujman near Qaffin (Site 106), and the fortified site at Kh. Mas'ud (Site 110). Most of the new settlements were founded during the Iron Age I (see Zertal 1994: 54–59). In the Iron Age IIa a group of fortified tells, typical of the whole region, was established, including 'Abeideh, Sheikh Şabar, Barṭa'ah, Kh. Mahu, Ferasin, Kh. 'Aqabah, and Umm edh-Dhiyab. Unfortified settlements were also founded close to them. The Persian period is less significant in this region, having been too far west to play a central role. From the beginning of the Roman period there was intensive and well-established settlement through the whole region.

Landscape Unit 25: The district of Narbatah

This is the largest of the units, 112 sq. km in area. At the same time, it is the most remote and least known. Most of the hilly landscape is uncultivated, with deep wadi beds, and is covered by Mediterranean thicket. As a result, it is sparsely inhabited even today. The geographical characteristics are similar to those of the hills of Ya'bad, and the separation between the units has been decided mainly according to the history of settlement.

The region is well defined. In the north – the Ghassal – Jiz watershed and the A3 road; in the west – the coastal plain, along the A1 road; in the south – the deep Wadi Massin, and in the east – the road from Deir Sharaf to the Dothan Valley (B6) and the hills north of the er-Rammeh Valley.

Formation, soil and water: like the hills of Ya'bad this region is formed by long narrow east-west ranges, the result of the faults which intersected the Shechem syncline. The main watershed between Wadis Jiz and Massin passes over the Faḥmeh – Kafr Ra'y – Şaidah – 'Illar range, with secondary ranges descending from it northward and southward. These ranges are built of layers of hard limestone with soft Senonian chalk on top, which create a wild and difficult area. The rock here is of the Judea Group in the south and the Avdat and Mount Scopus groups in the north.

The rocky area produces *terra rossa* and brown forest soil pockets among the boulders. In the small hilly plateaus, such as Dar el-Mutha'mnah, the Faḥmeh range, etc., continuous arable land is present, but is only partly cultivated. The *terra rossa* areas were used for olive groves, mainly during the Roman era, while the Mediterranean thicket has survived in many places.

The natural water sources are a group of small springs around Faḥmeh

and near Şeidah.

The major roads around the unit seem to have influenced the region only a little. The difficult topography hampered the construction of good roads, and only the Roman road to Narbatah (C₁), and the Mamluk Şeidah – ‘Illar – Ra’y – Faḥmeh road are noteworthy.

Fifty-seven sites have been found in the region. In spite of the similarity to the hills of the Ya’bad region, the characteristics of the sites here are different. Two Bronze Age tells were found: Tell Wadi el-Bir and Baṭn Umm Nari. Both are impressive fortified cities, being enclaves in the *maquis* which covered the region. It can be assumed that these two city-states, being hill-country cities of the Early Bronze Age (Zertal 2004: 46–50; 2008a: 71–75), played an important historical role. The Intermediate Bronze Age shows only one settlement, while seven sites were settled during the Middle Bronze Age II. Here also, forest clearance on a large scale began during Iron Age I, with 13 settlements found; over most of which fortified cities or settlements were established during the Iron Age II period, when a large settlement expansion in the hill country began. Prominent are the numerous fortified tells of the period (Kh. Ḥamam, Şeida, ‘Illar, el-Khirbeh (‘Arrabeh), Kh. el-Qureinat, Kh. Umm Kaḥal, el-Khirbeh (Ra’y), and Baṭn Umm Nari); with unfortified tells nearby (Dahrath Saffi, Kh. Shamsin). Another group is of the sites in the *Via Maris* area: the Jatt and ‘Ibthan Valleys, including the sites of Jatt and Yemmeh (along the road), and ‘Attil, Kh. Beit es-Sama, er-Rujjum, and Qubur ed-Dadaiyat.

From the Roman period onwards there has been constant settlement expansion throughout the area.

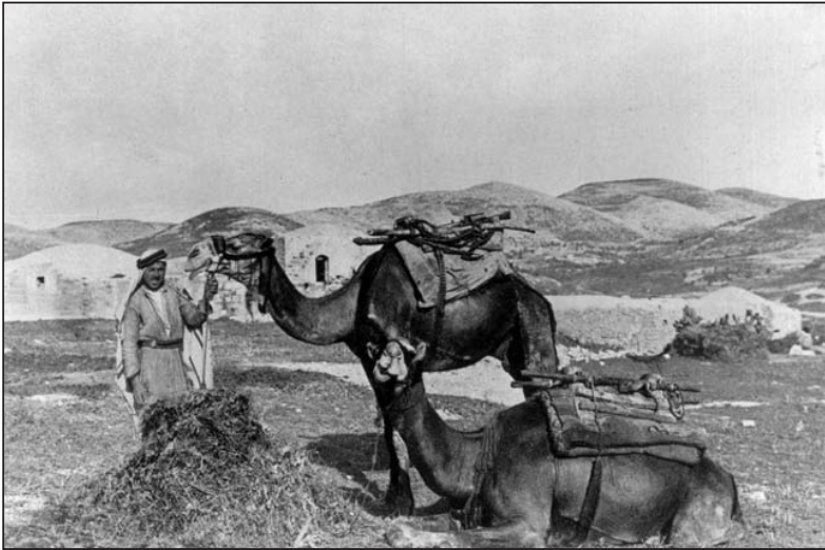
Landscape Unit 26: The area of Bal’ah

This is the smallest and the least inhabited of the units. This long narrow strip between Wadi Massin and Nahal Shechem is about 50 sq. km in area. It is the western part of the high hills, created by the faults of the ‘Anabtah anticline. The soil and vegetation are identical to the Narbatah region, but no water sources are known.

The Deir el-Ghuṣun – Nahal Shechem road along Wadi esh-Sham is possibly situated over an ancient road. Roll (1976: 39) has located the Roman road from Caesarea to Neapolis here, but no remains have been found. Robinson (1970, III: 124–125) suggests that the road from the coastal plain to er-Rammin passed here. Today, a difficult road runs along the top of the ridge from Bal’ah to Sirtassa (C₅).

Fifteen sites were discovered in this unit. They are far apart, possibly

because the rich Nahal Shechem valley to the south was preferred by settlers. The western sites belong more to the *Via Maris* line, and less to the hill country. Sparse settlement activity was recorded in the Bronze Age, and it was only in the Iron Age II that the number of sites increased. Four sites from the Persian period were found, and the small fort close to Wadi Massin (Kh. Wasil, Site 193) was already founded in the Middle Bronze Age, while the existing structure is Roman, and it seems that the site was used as a fort throughout the ages.



8. Load-carrying camels in Samaria, near Shechem. Until the 1930s the bulk of transportation in the region was by camel. Photo from Preiss and Rohrbach 1925:

D. THE SETTLEMENT BY PERIODS

Several reviews are presented in the Landscape Unit discussion; however, the material here is more comprehensive and is supported by maps of the periods.

The settlement analysis in this Volume complements that of the Shechem syncline in Volume 1 (Zertal 2004). To begin with, the north-western margins of the Shechem syncline, which is the main focus of this volume, are rocky and unfavourable for settlement. During the Chalcolithic and Bronze Ages (5th to 2nd millennia BCE) the territory was almost unpopulated, an advantage for the new settlers of the Iron Age. This vacuum encouraged the occupation of the Iron Age I, which was finally consolidated during the subsequent period, when the fortified tells of the northern Kingdom of Israel were founded. The outstanding prosperity in the Persian period, especially characteristic of the *pahwah* of Samaria, was also the result of the competition against the centre in Jerusalem, the settlement of Jews who returned from Babylon, the special attention of the Persian rulers to the *pahwah* of Samaria, and the unique ethnic blend of this province (see Zertal 2009).

1. Chalcolithic period

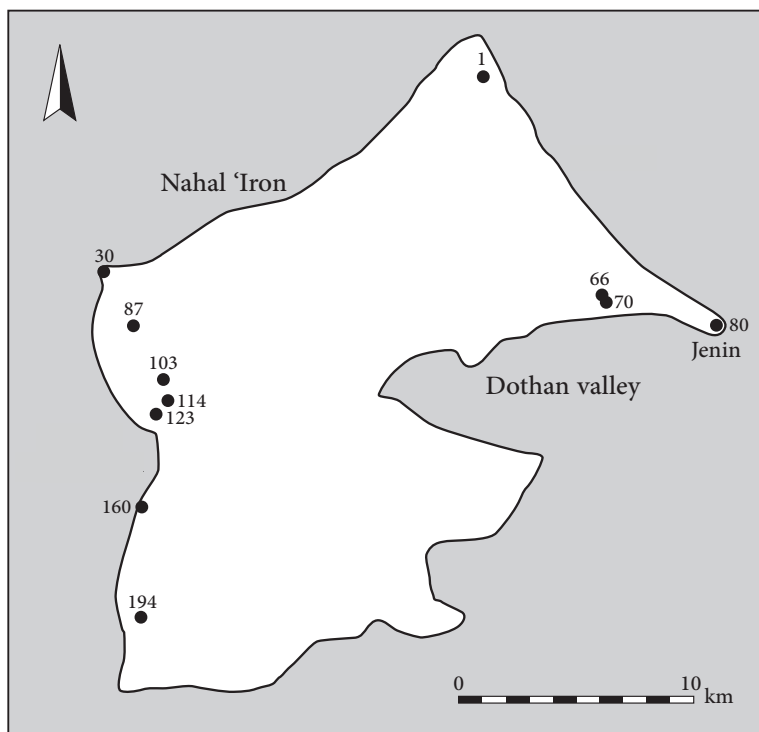
There are few settlements from this period, when the dependency on water sources and the economy did not encourage entry into the hill country. In the east, close to the Jezreel Valley, are sites such as 'Ein Qutein, 'Ein Hajjeh, and Bir Ḥanuni. In the north-west, near the border with the Sharon, is the large Neolithic and Chalcolithic site of 'En Esur, excavated by Yannai (1997; 2006), and some sites around Metzger-Baqa and Jatt-Zeita (West). The 11 sites found typify the edges of the territory, whereas the 400 sq. km of the surrounding hills are empty of settlement.

2. Early Bronze Age I-III

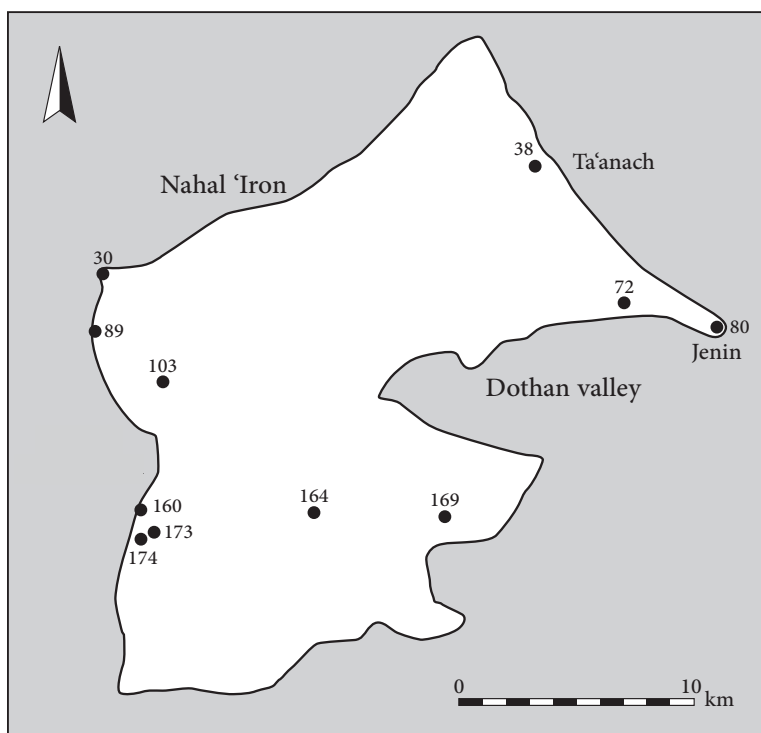
Only a few sites from these periods were found in north-western Manasseh. The 11 sites were concentrated in two areas: the inner Shechem syncline, close to the springs, and the border strips between the hills and the coastal plain and Jezreel Valley. The inner hill country, however, was covered with dense *maquis*, an obstacle to easy settlement in this period. As a result only a few of the fortified enclosures and tells were in the hills. Exceptional are those at Wadi el-Bir (Site 164) and Baṭn Umm Nari (Site 169), both situated

deep inside the hilly zone. The reason for their locations is probably the neighbouring water sources: however, there are also water sources with no Early Bronze Age sites.

Wadi el-Bir is an example of an Early Bronze Age city. It is particularly large (about 10 ha in area), and is separated from the surrounding hills by two deep wadis, and stretches at an angle over a gentle slope. It is situated next to the water source of Bir Siflani, with a circular acropolis at the top and visible fortifications. The place was founded during the Early Bronze Age I, and developed considerably in the following period. The city was not settled in the Middle Bronze and Iron Ages, an indication of conditions mainly suiting the Early Bronze Age inhabitants. There is a difference between the Wadi el-Bir site and the other large tells in the syncline (Umm el-Hawa – Zertal 2004: Site 68; el-Hawarrah – Zertal 2004: Site 79) and those of the Dothan Valley: Muhaffar, Bal'ameh, and Dothan. Those in the syncline enjoyed strategic advantages (elevation and observation), and those in the valley possessed extensive agricultural fields. The Wadi el-Bir



9. The Chalcolithic period sites.



10. The Early Bronze Age I–III sites.

site lacks both: it is low-lying, and the small areas of cultivable land are on the hilly slopes. It seems that its economy depended upon horticulture (and see a similar picture in eastern Samaria in Bar 2011; 2013; 2014).

Other tells were found along the margins: Jenin, Ta'anach, Megiddo, Jatt, and Shuweiket er-Ras. These were influenced by the international road, the advantages of the valley, topography, and the Sharon margins. Along the *Via Maris* there were also large settlements at Zeita (West) (Site 160) and Jebel Bir Zeita (Site 173).

3. *Intermediate Bronze Age (EB IV/MB I)*

The region was almost empty during this period. The three sites found, cemeteries near Tel Esur (Site 30), Kh. Yannun (Site 42), and Baqa el-Gharbiyeh (Site 129) are exceptions. However, the rich cemeteries excavated next to Tel Esur raise the question of where the population lived. In Volume 1 it is suggested that there were no settlements in the hills, and the sites

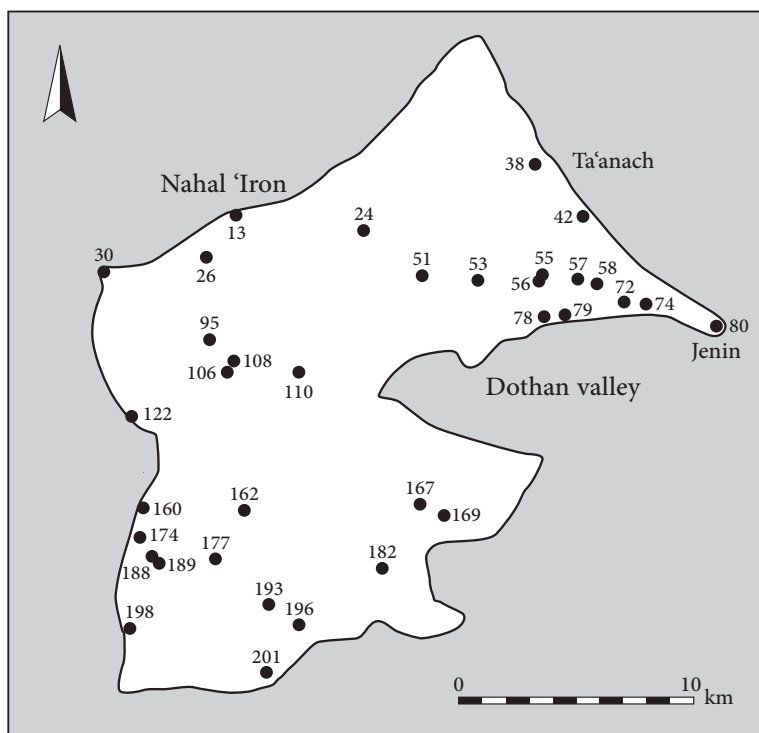
were either in the east or in the Sharon plain (Zertal 2004: 50–51). Recent discoveries of a large cluster of settlements in north-eastern Samaria (Bar et al. 2013) might be the answer to this question.

4. *Middle Bronze Age II*

The 34 sites of the period represent 17% of the total number of settlements in this Volume. Seven of them are multi-period tells near the roads; the rest are located in the hinterland.

Some of the fortified multi-period tells (e.g., Jenin, Ta'anach, 'Arunah, 'Attil, Shuweiket er-Ras, etc.), continued to exist from the Early Bronze Age, and some were first settled in the Middle Bronze Age (e.g., Tel Esur, and see Appendix F).

Excavated Tell Ta'anach (Site 38) is an example of a Middle Bronze Age site. An enclosure was built on top of the Early Bronze Age city, fortified with large earthen ramparts. It was constructed in the Middle Bronze Age



11. The Middle Bronze Age II sites.

I Ib, and was designated a 'camp' by Lapp, who dated it to 1700 BCE (Glock 1993: 1432). Rich finds, including burials in jars, were registered in the 'Noble's House' ('Western Building' – 1600 BCE). It seems to be a typical Middle Bronze Age city-state, which might have extended into the forested vicinity. The recently excavated Tel Esur (Appendix F) reveals a different story. Here the unique fortifications were erected in the Middle Bronze Age IIa, and the site was unfortified during the Middle Bronze Age IIb.

Most Middle Bronze Age II sites did not evolve into tells. Those that did include Kh. Rujum by Nahal 'Iron, Wadi Ḥardan near Faḥmeh, el-Khirbeh (Ra'y), Abu Rujman near Qaffin. Wadi Ḥardan is a small site fortified by a rampart, similar to those already found in the Shechem syncline (Zertal 2004: sites 54, 196).

Also worth noting are the clusters of settlements next to Wadi Ḥasan, and in the Jezreel Valley margins, where 13 sites were found.

In the 2nd millennium BCE, much as in the 3rd, the inner valleys offered conditions more attractive than the hill country. The population did not push into the hills, which remained densely forested. Exceptions are the small fortified sites of Tell Umm Zeid and Kh. Mas'ud. These two are surrounded by earthen ramparts, 5 to 10 m high, which created a podium, on top of which stood a small fort or a tower. Both sites were possibly built to control the surrounding area. Tell Umm Zeid could have been an outpost of Tell Ta'anach; and Kh. Mas'ud, of Tell Dothan or Jatt.

5. Late Bronze Age

The settlement of the Middle Bronze Age turned into emptiness in the Late Bronze Age. Most sites from the preceding period declined or disappeared, and apart from a single cemetery (er-Requq, which is difficult to explain), there were almost no settlements. The 14 remaining sites were on existing tells at the margins of the hills (e.g. Ta'anach, Megiddo, 'Arunah, Esur, and Shuweiket er-Ras), and also at Kh. Yannun and Khariqet er-Ras. Thus this district became a model for the relative vacuum preceding the Israelite settlement.

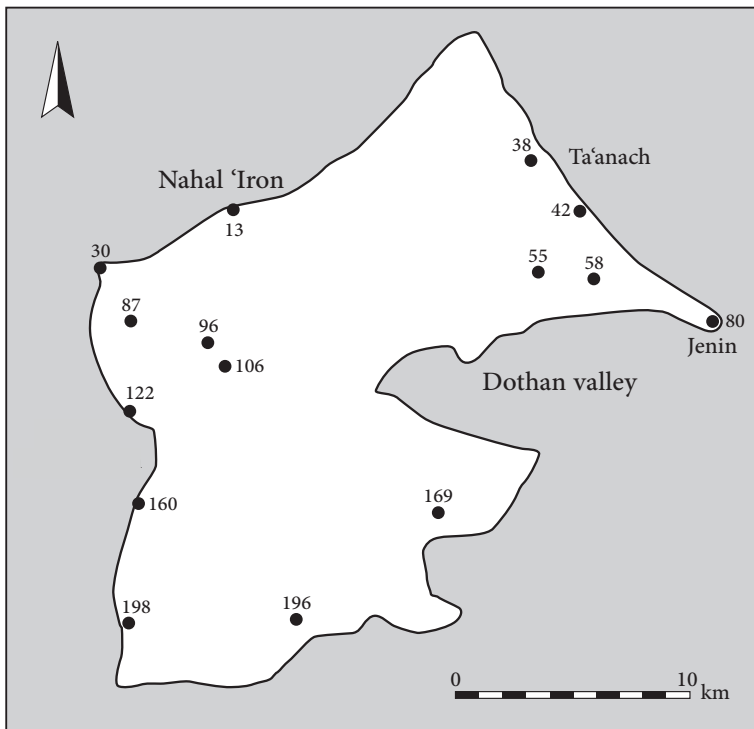
6. Iron Age I

This is the first large occupation of the hill country, almost completely vacant in the preceding period. Sherds of the period were found at 50 sites (24.8% of the total in this Volume), mostly founded in rough areas, short of water and far from roads and arable land.

These new sites are divided into two groups: those which were built over existing multi-period tells, and those which were newly founded on virgin soil in the hills. The 22 sites of the second group (almost half of the total of the period) seem to be the earliest of the period.

The Israelite settlers who found the inner valleys fully or partly occupied ascended into the hills and established new settlements. This process was first mentioned by Gophna and Porath (1972: 199), who wrote: "...unfortified settlements are being founded again in the hill country's various areas...many of them were established in areas of solid limestone lacking water springs... it seems that the Israelite settlers settled at first in uninhabited areas of the land... This might explain the absence of Biblical Conquest traditions of the tribe of Manasseh". In addition, the rich Biblical traditions are evidence of the process, perhaps from a different angle (see Chapter Four).

Most of the new settlements were founded in the landscape units of Ya'bad, Narbatah, and Bal'ah. It seems that in the units of Ta'anach and the fringes of the Jezreel Valley was a considerable Canaanite presence, with



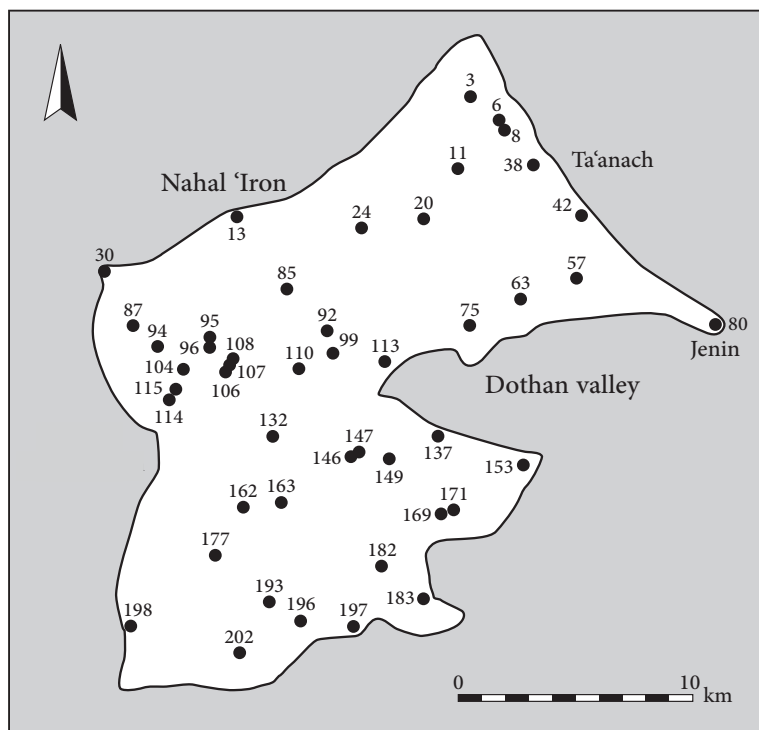
12. The Late Bronze Age sites.

only a few new Iron Age I settlements.

El-Aḥwat in Nahal 'Iron is an exception: it is a large, well-planned and fortified town. Its fortifications and architecture differed from the usual Iron Age I site, with uncharacteristic corridors and round structures. The site survived for about two generations, and was then abandoned. Different considerations and the uniqueness of the place raised the possibility of relating it to the northern Sea Peoples, presumably the *Shardana* tribe from Sardinia. Other similar sites were discovered in the area of modern Kerem Maharal in southern Carmel (not in this Volume).

As already suggested, studying a single-period site is preferable for understanding the Iron Age I period. Three such settlements – el-Wakr near Qaffin, er-Ras near er-Rammeh, and Abu Rish near Şeida, are good candidates for this group.

A typical Iron Age I site is small in area (1,000–2,000 sq. m), in most cases situated on the summit or slope of a hill. The architecture is simple, and storage vessels are prominent among the rough pottery assemblage.

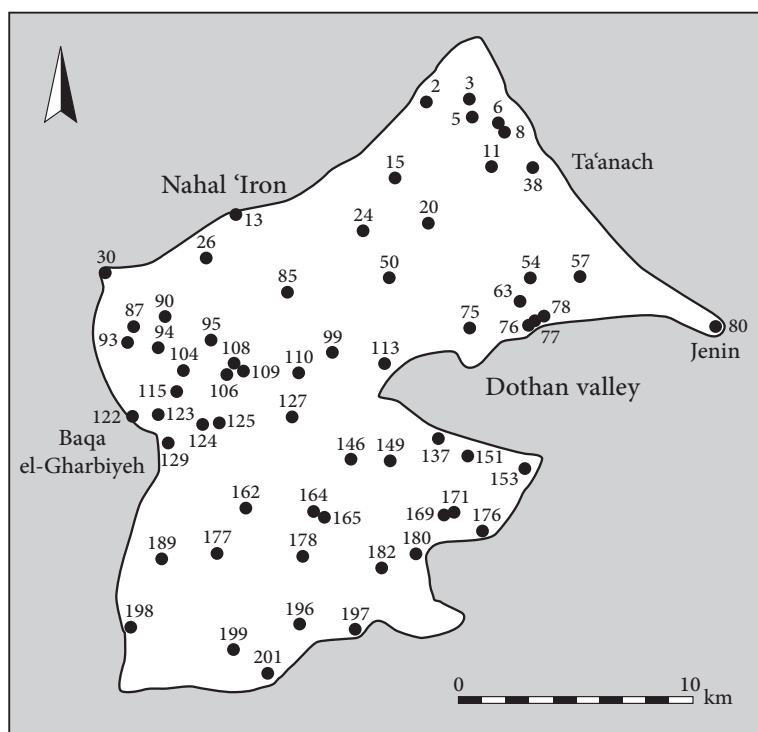


13. The Iron Age I sites.

The sites were mostly settled inside the Mediterranean *maquis*, in order to use the land after clearing the vegetation. In many cases they continued into Iron Age II (the Israelite Northern Kingdom), a fact pointing to the possible relationship of the two societies.

7. Iron Age II

The number of sites grew from Iron Age I (50 sites) to Iron Age II (63 sites). The nature of the sites also changed: a large number of fortified towns (17 sites) were established, mostly on top of small Iron Age I sites. They were mostly located upon a summit, controlling the vicinity (Salem, el-Baṭn, Barta'ah, 'Abeidah, Tell esh-Sheikh Šabar, Kh. Beidus, Kh. Mahu, Kh. Umm edh-Dhiyab, 'Illar, 'Attil, Kh. Ḥamam, and Umm Kaḥal) or on a hill above the plain (Ferasin, Kh. Bir el-'Isyar). The tops of these hills were surrounded by stone walls, creating a terrace-like circle. Most of these summits are now cultivated and planted, but they still contain remains of buildings, walls, and cisterns. Their location seems to be influenced by



14. The Iron Age II sites.

the defensive criterion of positioning a fortified tell every 5–6 km in the area. Such a concept is different from other periods, and we are inclined to see military planning here. Around the tells are small unfortified sites: villages or farms, 1–5 ha in area. None of the single-stratum Iron Age II villages was fully preserved, due to the fact that buildings were almost always constructed over them in later periods. Some Arab villages (Şeida, 'Illar) are also situated over sites of this period.

During the 9th–8th centuries BCE the settlement of the hill country seems to have been completed, with optimal dispersion of sites. Construction of terraces and agricultural installations, reached its first peak (the second was in the Byzantine period). Excavation of cisterns in hard chalk, not common earlier, liberated the population from its dependency upon springs.

8. Iron Age III (the Assyrian Conquest)

During this period a drastic decline occurred, and there were only 10 sites, although this number is not certain. This sharp decline in the number of settlements was possibly due to the Assyrian exile. Most of the survey here was conducted at the end of the 70s and the beginning of the 80s of the 20th century, when the unique 'Cuthean' bowl was unknown (Zertal 1990). In more modern times additional sites would probably have been attributed to this period. Only with the new understanding of this unique vessel could the period have been defined with certainty.

One of our conclusions is that most of the Israelite population remained in the area, but with a noticeable decline. As for geography, only a few of the exiled population brought from afar was settled by the Assyrian authorities in the west of the region, and they were concentrated between Samaria, Tel Far'ah-Tirzah, and Shechem.

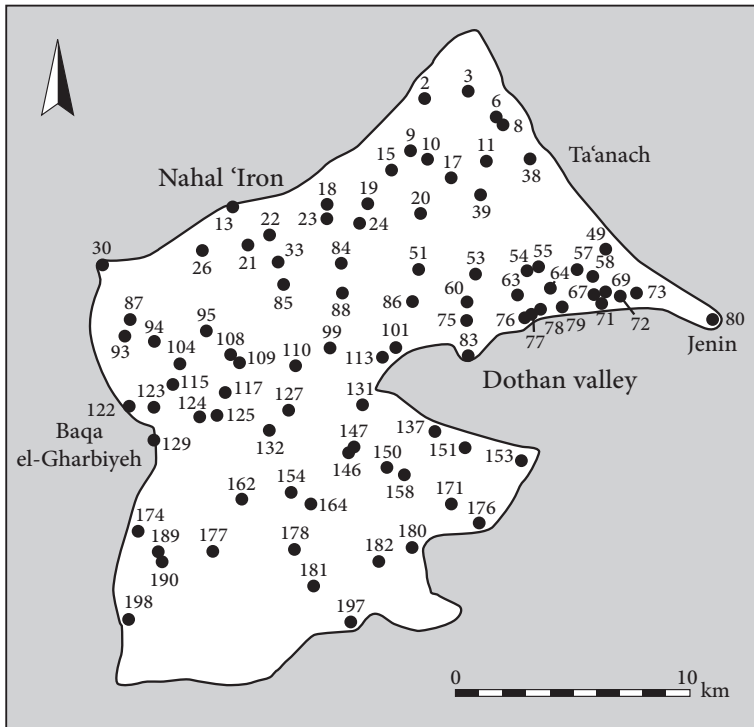
9. Persian period

As in the northern Shechem syncline, the north-western margins flourished during this period. In 87 sites, 43% of the total of this volume, sherds of the period were found. Most of the earlier sites continued to exist, with new ones established: 32 settlements, 38% of the total in the Persian period, were founded on virgin soil (or after a gap of more than one whole period). In conclusion, the Persian period is remarkable in its intensity. The sites are well spread over the territory, with concentrations at the Jezreel Valley margins, the hills of Ta'anach (24 sites), and in Nahal 'Iron (19 sites).

In the south and the west of the region the number only slightly decreases. The north of the Shechem syncline, mainly in the Dothan Valley and its margins (Zertal 2004), was densely settled. Between the Dothan Valley and Nahal 'Iron there is at least one Persian site per square kilometre. Among them are fortified cities like el-Batn, el-Kharaiyyeq, and Tell 'Abeidah, and many farms. The farms comprise a dwelling building, a yard, structures for animals, and installations (vats, wineries). The family farm was already known in Iron Age II, but now it flourished. A possible historic explanation, based on the Book of Judith, is the intense settlement in the Dothan Valley (Grintz 1957; Zertal 2009).

The Wadi Ḥasan sites with the military Persian fort in er-Ras (Site 101) and the camp (?) at es-Sahlat (B) (Site 67) can also be linked to the Book of Judith. The last site, an empty square camp, was encircled by a thick wall with towers, with a plan similar to the 'Assyrian' camp at el-Qa'adeh (Zertal 2004: site 154).

El-Kharaiyyeq, a fortified settlement on the summit of a high hill



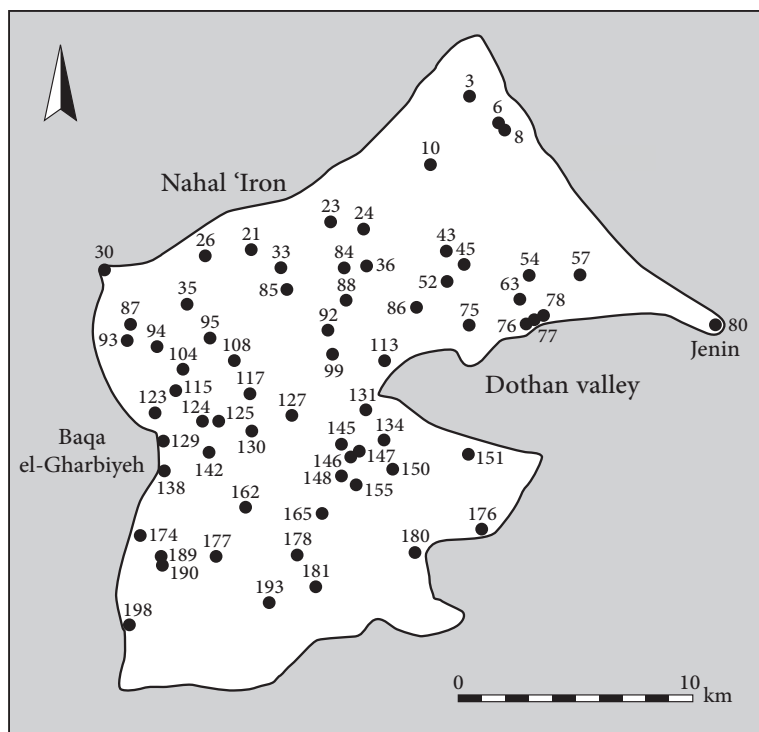
15. The Persian period sites.

between the Dothan and Jezreel Valleys, was identified by us as Bethulia, the home town of Judith (Zertal 2009).

10. Hellenistic period

A new entity now appears: the *toparchy* of Arbata/Narbatah, reaching its peak in the time of Herod. The 67 sites of the Hellenistic period (33% of the total in this Volume), are only three-quarters of the number of sites of the Persian period. This decrease is possibly connected to the punishment meted out by the troops of Alexander the Great (Zertal 2004: 60–61). If so, this blow was less severe in the region of central Samaria, according to the results of other surveys.

Not many new sites were founded; most of them continuing from the preceding period. An exception is the Jezreel Valley margins, where more than half of the Persian sites disappeared. The Bethulia region (in the Book of Judith) was the most seriously depopulated, and the hub moved to the



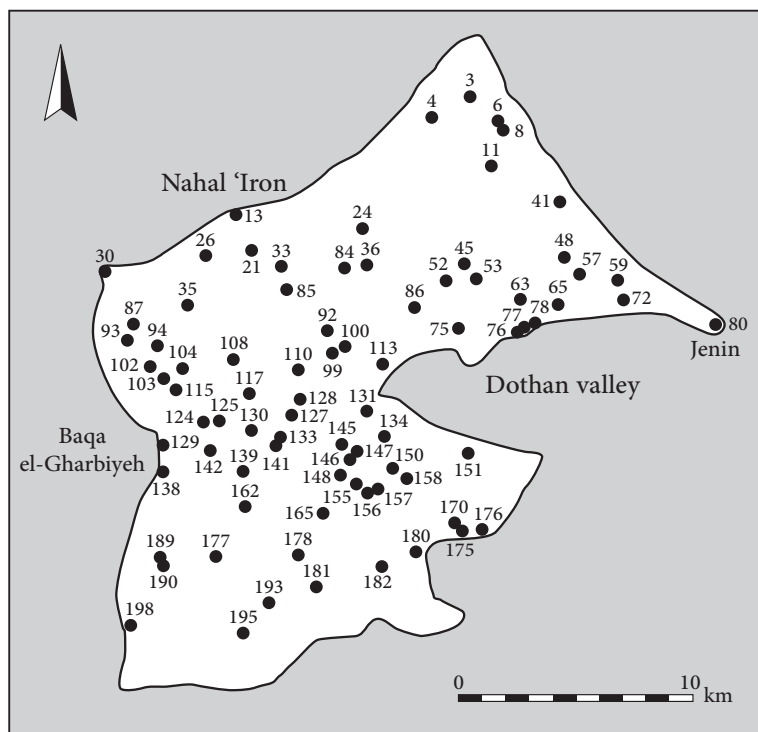
16. The Hellenistic period sites.

Narbatah area, which became a centre of settlement until the end of the Great Revolt against the Romans.

11. *Early Roman period*

An increase in the number of settlements was noted, and in 86 sites (19 more than in the Hellenistic period) sherds from Herod's time, ending with the Great Revolt in 66 CE, were found. In the Narbatah district there was a significant increase; the number of sites grew from 19 in the Hellenistic period to 26 in the Herodian period, a proof of the importance of the district. A possible reason for the process is the remoteness of this district, far from central government and roads, and therefore convenient for the creation of an independent Jewish entity. We believe that at this stage the 'Narbatah stronghold' of the Jews was formed.

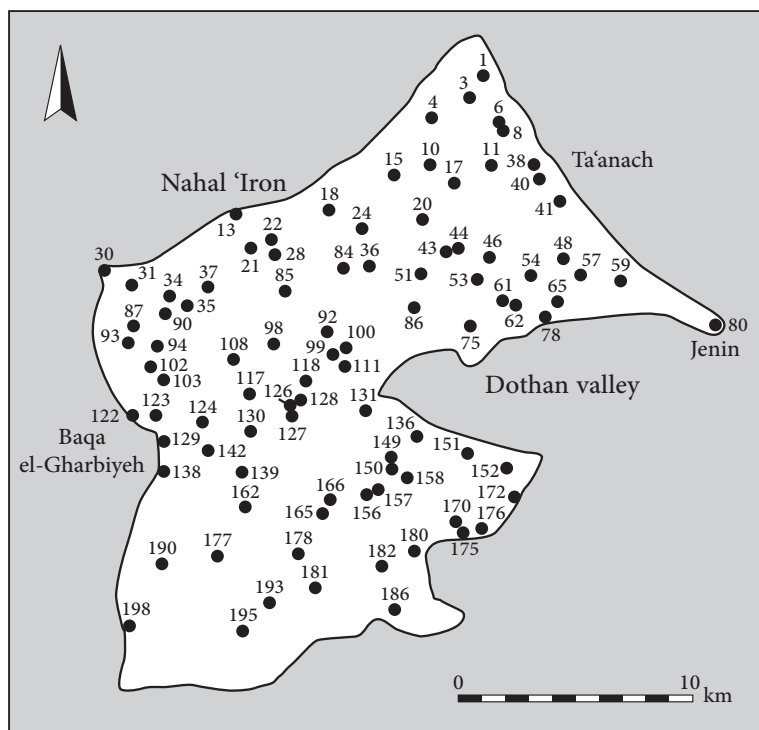
Kh. el-Ḥamam (Arbatah/Narbatah) was now the main city, according to historical sources. It was besieged by the Romans and fell in 66 CE.



17. The Early Roman period sites.

Among the many villages which surrounded the town are Kh. Samarraḥ, Kh. 'Arar, Dahret es-Ṣafi, Faḥmeh (with an ancient synagogue), Baṭn Khan-zir, Barquneh, Umm Kashaf, and others. Their relationship to the Toparchy of Nabatah is based upon the fact that they were all abandoned – according to the sherds – at the end of the period. The possible Roman camp at Tell Mughur seems to have been connected to the military activity around Nabatah.

A similar increase in the number of sites was noted in the neighbouring districts – the hills of Ya'bad. Examples are the fortified Herodian sites at Tell esh-Sheikh Ṣabar and Tell 'Abeidah. Umm Riḥan, founded in the Hasmonean period, also reached its maximum size in this period. Typical Herodian masonry was also noted at Qaṣr 'Ein esh-Sheri'ah. Over the rest of the region the Herodian settlement was built on top of the Hellenistic one, and also here – except in the Nabatah district – few new settlements were founded.



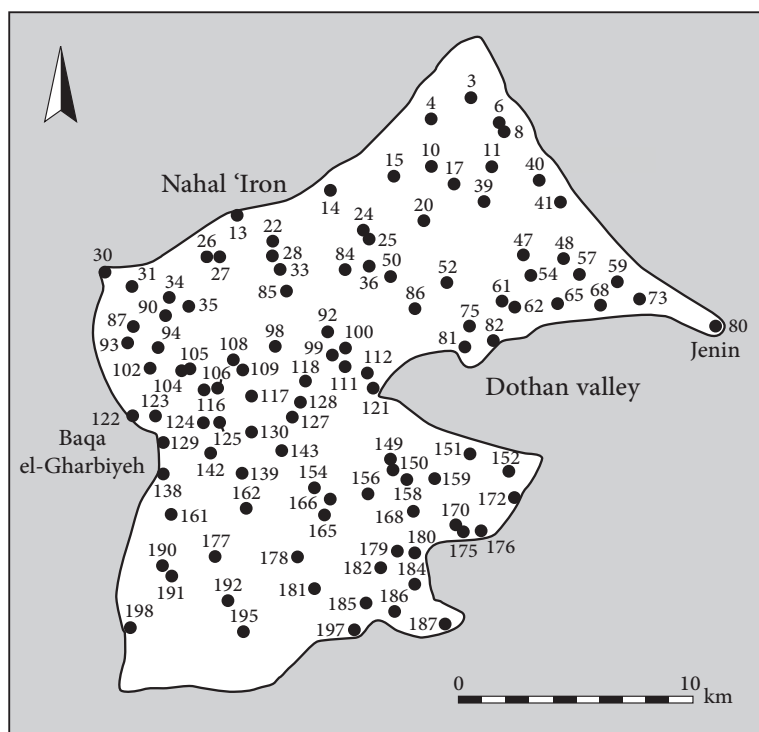
18. The Late Roman period sites.

12. Late Roman and Byzantine periods

These periods are notable for their continuity, the large number of settlements (91 – Late Roman, and 109 – Byzantine), and by their locations. Several other developments should be noted. The two Roman forts established for the security of roads and springs are Kh. Mu'allaqeh and Kh. Madar. Another, probably to guard the entrance to Wadi Massin, was built at Kh. Wasil. All these are of the square courtyard type without towers. New farms were also founded, whereas in most of the sites the preceding period habitation continued.

The Byzantine period saw a settlement expansion. The 109 sites, which represent a significant addition to the existing Roman ones, are partly related to the expansion of the Samaritan population. Some settled in the Jewish Narbatah District, while others left the district for the cities of the coastal plain.

At that period, and possibly in the preceding one, most of the present-day Arab villages were founded, and have continued to exist ever since.



19. The Byzantine period sites.

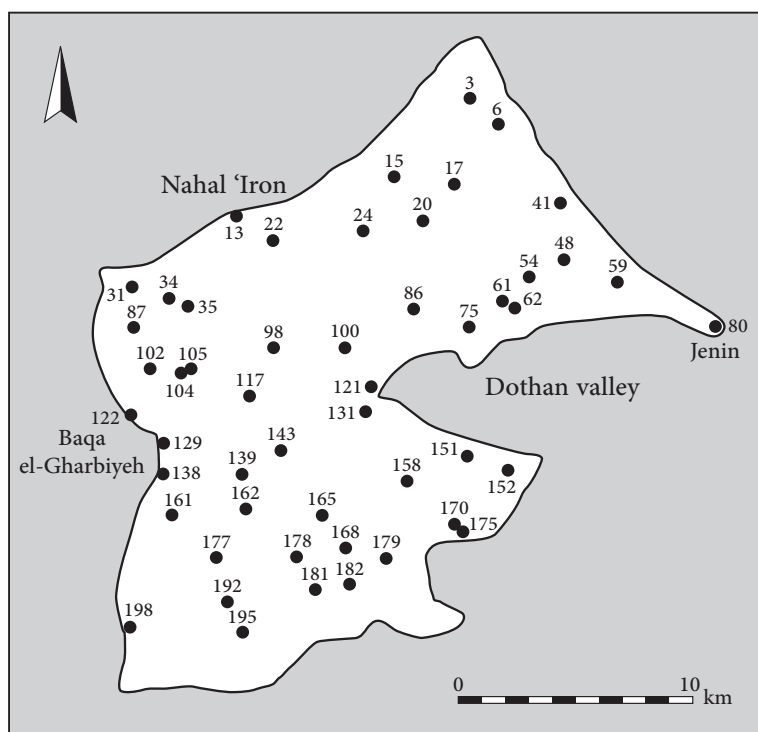
13. Early Moslem period

An acute habitation crisis occurred during this period. Of the 109 Byzantine sites, only 50 (46%) survived to the Early Moslem period. In all the landscape units about half of the Byzantine sites were abandoned. The crisis was particularly severe in the Ya'bad hills, where only 10 of 30 the Byzantine sites survived.

The reasons for this abandonment are not clear. It was possibly due to the relations between Samaritans, Christians, and the Moslem conquerors. However, it should also be noted that it was not always easy to differentiate between Late Byzantine and Early Moslem pottery during the survey, and therefore the whole issue requires more thorough research.

14. The Medieval period

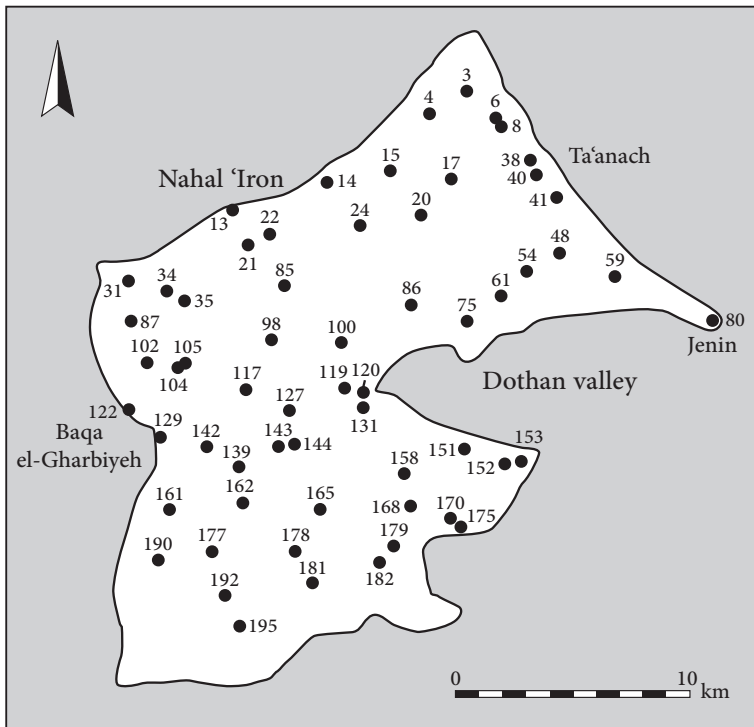
This period includes the reigns of the Umayyad and Abbasid Dynasties, the Crusader era, and the Mamluk period. The accounts by Moslem travellers



20. The Early Moslem period sites.

and Crusader sources mention many sites in the region.

From the settlement angle, a slight recovery can be seen: in comparison to the 50 sites of the earlier period, various phases of Medieval sherds were found in 60 sites. The increase is notable in Nahal 'Iron, the hills of Ya'bad, and the Narbatah district, and could be connected to the development of the Arab villages. In some of the villages, a pause has been noticed in the Early Moslem period, followed by a recovery in the Middle Ages, when they appear in the Crusaders' records as estates (*casales*). Such is the situation in Barta'ah, Kh. Saffet, Baqa el-Gharbiyeh, and others. A rise can also be seen during the Middle Ages in the Shechem syncline; possibly Mam-luk settlement (Zertal 2004: 66–67); but this requires much additional research and evaluation. It is also possible that the 'messenger's route' via Jenin – 'Arrabeh – Faḥmeh – Şeida – 'Illar might have been a factor in the development of settlement in this area.

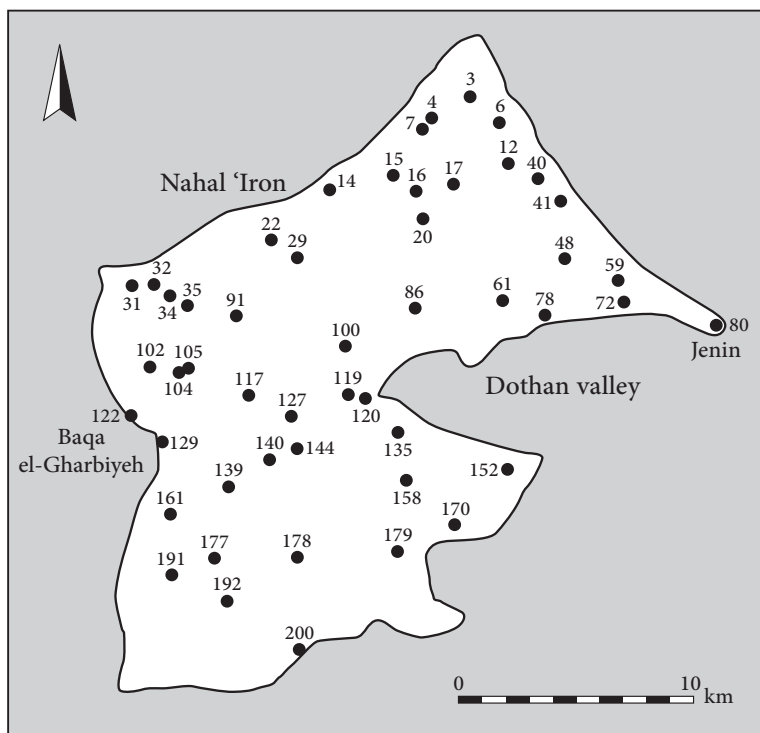


21. The Medieval sites.

15. Ottoman period

A moderate decline of settlement can be seen during the 400 years of Ottoman rule, and political and economic neglect of the country was evident mainly towards its end. The end of the 19th century saw a decline, and the villages which survived were almost all Arab. Of the 60 Medieval sites, only 50 were occupied in the Ottoman period. In the 19th century several small sites, such as Umm el-'Abhar, Sheikh Iskandar, and Kh. Haffur were founded, but on the other hand, inhabited villages were deserted. Such was the case at Jemah Tubrus and Ferasin, both abandoned.

Of a total of 28 modern Arab villages within the Survey area, 24 were inhabited during the Ottoman period. Most of the population was concentrated in villages whose centre was fortified and the poor state of security and the shrinking population made it difficult for family farms to survive. Even the three cities of the region, Jenin, Tulkarm, and Shechem, were small and wretched townships.



22. The Ottoman period sites.

E. OUTLINE OF THE HISTORY OF THE REGION

Due to the limited area of the exploration, no thorough analysis of the historical events is presented here. Instead, this chapter will concentrate on comparing the historical background with the archaeological material.

1. *Bronze Age*

Historical records of the Early Bronze Age are extremely limited. Judging by the series of fortified tells along the edges of the Sharon plain, it seems that the ancient main road (the *Via Maris*) was already active. These ancient cities (Shuwiket er-Ras, Jatt, Zeitah, Yemmeh, etc.) were first discussed by Gophna (1974).

As for the 2nd millennium BCE, most of the records again deal with the international road and the 'Arunah pass. However, the Egyptian sources, widely discussed in the literature, have not been thoroughly explored archaeologically and geographically. Aspects such as site distribution, topography, soil and water, flora and others, have barely received attention, while our research was able to contribute some data.

The Execration Texts add little information (Sethe 1926; Posener 1940). Mazar (1980b: 24) identified E5 of Posener's list (*Mktry*) with Migdal in the Sharon, and site 71 in the list of Thutmose III. *Kn* (E7) was identified with the area of Gina (*Kur-Gina*) of EA letter 250 (Moran 1987: 475–477).

As already shown, a detailed record of the area and the *Via Maris* is in Thutmose III's diary of his first campaign in 1485 BCE (ANET: 234–238). The council of the Egyptian army command, before crossing the hills to the Jezreel valley, took place at *Yhm*, presumably today's Kh. Yemmeh. The two relevant crossing roads are described in Thutmose III's diary: "Now two (other) roads are here. One of the roads – behold, it is [*to the east of*] us, so that it comes out at Ta'anach. The other – behold, it is to the north of Megiddo." (ANET: 235). These roads were surveyed by our team and the following remarks should be added:

1. Thutmose III's 'eastern' road, which entered the Jezreel valley near Ta'anach, should have passed through the Dothan valley and then Wadi Hasan. Not only is this the shortest and most logical pass, but a later record from the Persian period (Book of Judith; Grintz 1957) calls it "the great pass to Judah" (Jdt 3: 10). In addition, most of the Middle-Late Bronze Age sites of the 2nd millennium are located along this road.
2. The identification of *Djefti* with Tel Esur from Thutmose III's records

(see Na'aman 1984) is now supported by the discovery of Late Bronze Age strata in the recent excavations at the site (see Appendix F). Another factor is that the three roads crossing the hills are indicated by towns: Ta'anach (eastern road), Megiddo (central), and Djefti (northern). If this identification is correct, Aharoni's (1958) suggestion to identify Djefti as Kh. Sit Leila no longer holds.

3. The entrance into the 'Arunah pass should have been through Wadi Samantar, starting near modern Kibbutz Metzger, and connecting to the pass before 'Arunah. This new identification also explains the fact that no settlements are mentioned in Thutmose III's text along the road (except 'Arunah). This is the situation all along this route during the Late Bronze Age.

The inner section of the pass was always along the 'Arunah valley, which is wide and easily travelled, with several water sources. Control of the 'Arunah fortress was vital to protect the road.

4. The outlet into the Jezreel valley was along narrow Wadi Qinah, modern Wadi Bu'einah. This is the only road which matches the conditions described by the records of Thutmose III and Hori.

The el-Amarna letters are the next historical record, dealing with the territories of northern Samaria, the Dothan valley, Megiddo, and the events related to Labayu's family. Letter EA 250 describes their effort to spread into the Jezreel Valley. On the other hand Gath-Padallah, with its prince Baal-Ur-Sag, has been identified as modern Jatt (Rainey 1968). Ḥarabu and Burqunah of letter EA 250 should have probably been at el-Khrab (Zertal 2004: site 27) and Burqin (Zertal 2004: site 13), in the west and the east of the Dothan Valley respectively (Zertal 1984: 60–61; 2004: 71–72). To these we should now add the possible identification of Gintirimmunima (EA 250 line 46 – Moran 1987: 475–477) at Kh. Yannun (site 42). Gintiasnah (EA 319, Moran 1987: 543), on the other hand, was possibly located at Khariqet er-Ras (site 55), while Nuribdah (EA 365, Moran 1987: 560–561) – in Baṭn Umm Nari (site 169). To sum up, the 'Ginah country' of the EA letters matches the modern area of Jenin, where most of the sites were identified.

Some contradiction occurs when comparing the rich information in the EA letters and the archaeological reality. The Late Bronze Age sites are few and relatively small, and no settlements of the period were found in the hilly inner country (the landscape units of Bal'ah and Narbatah) except Baṭn Umm Nari.

Papyrus Anastasi I (ANET: 476–479), of the period of Ramses II, presents important information about the area in the 13th century BCE. This

'satirical letter' is a conversation between two Egyptian couriers, one questioning the other. The description of a narrow, dangerous ravine is as follows: "Thou art the mahir, experienced in deeds of heroism. A mahir such as thou art should be found (able) to stride at the head of an army! O maryanu, forward to shoot! Behold, the ambushade is in a ravine two thousand cubits deep, filled with boulders and pebbles. Thou makest a detour, as thou graspest the bow."... "The narrow valley is dangerous with Bedouins, hidden under the bushes. Some of them are of four to five cubits (*from*) their noses to the heel, and fierce of face. Their hearts are not mild and they do not listen to wheedling. Thou art alone; there is no messenger with thee, no army host behind thee. Thou findest no scout that might make thee a way of crossing. Thou comest to a decision by going forward, although thou knowest not the road. Shuddering seizes thee, (*the hair of*) thy head stands up, and thy soul lies in thy hand. Thy path is filled with boulders and pebbles, without a toehold for passing by, overgrown with reeds, thorns, brambles and 'wolf-paw'. The ravine is on one side of thee, and the mountain rises on the other. Thou goest on jolting and thy chariot on its side, afraid to press thy horse (too) hard. If it should be thrown toward the abyss, thy collar-piece would be left uncovered and thy girth would fall. Thou unfastenest the yoke in order to repair the collar-piece in the middle of the narrow valley...The ... is left were it is; the harness is (already) too heavy to carry its weight. Thy heart is disgusted. Thou startest to trot. The sky is opened. If only thou hadst a hedge of shrubs, that thou mightest put it on the other side! The horse is played out by the time thou findest a night-quarter. Thou seest the taste of pain!" (ANET: 477-478).

Is this the 'Arunah pass? No human settlement between Megiddo and Jaffa is mentioned in the letter, and the presence of wild Bedouin with no clear road – all may point to an unimportant and neglected area. It seems, in consequence, that the 'Arunah pass was not used as the main caravan road, because no other route in the Egyptian Empire is so remote and neglected. A similar argument appears in Thutmosis' text: his generals in the *Yhm* council advise him not to use the 'Arunah pass because of its dangers and obstacles.

In addition, it is not easy to explain the absence of 'Arunah and Esur (Djefti?) from the Anastasi Papyrus, as well as from Shishak's list of the 10th century BCE, when 'Arunah only was settled. It may that these two sites not had been settled in the 13th century BCE.

Shishak's list poses new problems. Along the 13 km distance between Megiddo and 'Arunah six sites are mentioned, 'Arunah (known from other

records), Adar (no. 28 in the Shishak list), Yad-hamelech (no. 29), unknown (no. 30), Henam (no. 31), and finally Arun (no. 32). It is not only that this number of places is unprecedented, but no sites of the early Iron Age II (10th century BCE) have been found in the survey along this line. One possibility is that these places were just landmarks along the road and not real settlements, and other explanations are possible.

In conclusion, it may be suggested that the road more used for trade and military passed through the Dothan Valley. This appears to be a highway in some sources, like the Joseph story in Gen 37.

2. Iron Age

While the later Biblical narratives, from the book of I Sam onwards, do not deal much with northern Samaria and the territory of the house of Joseph, it is the description in Josh 17: 11–13 which should be compared with the finds. The verse is as follows: “And Manasseh had in Issachar and in Asher Beth Shean and her towns, and Ibleam and her towns, and the inhabitants of Dor and her towns, and the inhabitants of En-Dor and her towns, and the inhabitants of Ta’anach and her towns, and the inhabitants of Megiddo and her towns, even three countries. Yet the children of Manasseh could not drive out the inhabitants of those cities; but the Canaanites would dwell in the land. Yet it came to pass, when the children of Israel were waxen strong, that they put the Canaanites to tribute; but did not utterly drive them out.”

The date of this narrative is not very clear, although some data about the Canaanite cities mentioned in the record may help. Canaanite (Late Bronze Age) presence was recorded in the Megiddo excavations, Str. VII–VI, in Beth-Shean Str. VI–V, and possibly also at Ta’anach.

At the same time, the information provided by the survey supports an early date of the Josh 17 traditions. The Israelites were prevented, according to this book, from descending to the fertile Jezreel Valley, a statement supported by the presence of only a few early Iron Age sites along the margins of the valley. From the verse quoted and the survey results additional conclusions are possible. Firstly, the sparse Late Bronze Age presence in the hill-country generally suits the Josh narratives. Secondly, the vague division between the boundaries of Manasseh, Asher, and Issachar in Josh 17 can be explained by the mixture of Canaanite cities and the few Israelite villages along the valley. The Canaanite cities were probably a barrier between the Israelite clusters of settlements. In addition, it can be suggested that the very idea of a difference between tribal territories had not

been yet crystallized.

Along Nahal 'Iron (the 'Arunah pass) there were only two sites in the Late Bronze Age. During Iron Age I the number of sites grew to 10. The Iron Age I sites mentioned in the Biblical narratives and in the general area are Dothan, Ta'anach, Ibleam, and Gath-Rimon, possibly to be identified as the village of Rummaneh.

The site of el-Aḥwat near Nahal 'Iron (Zertal 2012) is an exception to the general pattern of settlement of the area, as it differs from the others in both location and nature. The contrast between this site and other contemporary cultures in Canaan, where Israelites, Canaanites, Egyptians, and Philistines lived, led to the idea of a foreign origin. Its fortifications, inner division, and unique architecture – resembling the Bronze Age Nuraghic culture of Sardinia – suggest that the place was settled by a tribe of the Sea-Peoples – the Shardana.

This tribe was already previously known in the EA letters (no. 81, line 16; no. 122, line 35; no. 123, line 15, and see Moran 1987: 260–262, 333–335), with its men as mercenaries of Rib-Hadda, Prince of Byblos. They also appear in Egyptian service and fighting against them at the same time, and also during the 13th century BCE (Loretz 1995). Having a special status, they are described as changing loyalties between the courts at the end of the Late Bronze Age. Ramses III settled them in 'forts' in about 1180 BCE, following his victory over the Sea Peoples, providing them with rations (ANET: 262). The name-list of Amenophis about 1100 BCE (Gardiner 1947: 194–199) indicates their presence near the coast of Canaan about this date, together with the Philistines and the *Skḷ*. If el-Aḥwat indeed belonged to the Shardana, it may indicate their first area of settlement.

During Iron Age II the settlements grew in quantity and quality. The district-list of King Solomon in I Kgs 4: 3–15 includes the Manassite territory within Solomon's Third District. The discovery and identification of the town of Arubboth (I Kgs 4: 10) at Kh. el-Ḥamam (Site 146) supports the idea that King Solomon created new foci of political power. As the capital of the Third District, Arubboth symbolized the transition of power from the old Canaanite cities (Socoh, Ta'anach, Dothan, Ibleam, and Shechem) to the newly founded capitals.

However, the Biblical author uses ex-Canaanite towns to define the district boundaries: "The son of Heseḏ, in Arubboth; to him pertained Socoh, and all the land of Hephher" (see Zertal 1984: 65–72). The "Land of Hephher" here means a territory of an ex-Canaanite city-state with its 'daughters', which were later sub-districts of the settlement of Israelite families.

The people of Manasseh settled first in the interior of the hilly area, while the contacts with the Canaanites occurred along the edges of the Dothan Valley, the Sharon, and the Jezreel Valley. Adding this information to the survey results, an early date (12th century BCE or slightly later) for the narratives of Josh 17 is again well supported.

Unlike the Egyptian sources, the Bible (including the account of Pharaoh Necho II's campaign in the spring of 609 BCE) does not mention the 'Arunah pass or the tells along the *Via Maris*: Yemmeh, Esur-Djefti (?), or 'Arunah itself; only Socoh and Megiddo being indicated (II Kgs 2: 23, 29; 35, 22–23).

Discussing roads, we have already seen that it was the Dothan road which is mentioned in the Joseph story (Gen 37: 17–36): "a company of Ishmaelites coming from Gilead...carry it down to Egypt". It seems, therefore, that this convenient road was much preferred over the difficult 'Arunah pass.

In the Samaria Ostraca, a record dating to the 8th century BCE, no direct mention of this territory appears. If, as we believe, the division of Manassite 'clans' covered the whole of the tribal territory, then the areas mentioned in the Ostraca should fit the general boundaries of the tribe. One of the aims of future research will be to identify the different sites of the Ostraca, and fully understand the 'clan' division.

3. *Persian period*

From about 530 to 330 BCE, defined as the period of Persian-Achaemenid rule, the area discussed here continued to play an important role.

Among the historical records, the Book of Judith (see especially Moore 1992) seems to be directly and especially relevant. The main theme of this book is the punitive expedition to the Levant, led by the general Holofernes on behalf of 'Nebuchadnezzar, King of the Assyrians' (Jdt 2). This 'legendary' monarch is to be identified, according to many scholars, with the Persian King Artaxerxes II Mnemon (404–358 BCE) or Artaxerxes III Ochus (358–338 BCE).

During the campaign Holofernes and his army entered a territory settled by an ethnic Israelite group in the northern Samaria region close to the Dothan Valley. This community refused to surrender to the King, an act which led Holofernes and his army to lay a siege to their main town – Bethuliya. At the centre of the story stands Judith, a Jewish heroine, who saved the city and the Jews by beheading the general after making him

drunk.

The reality of the book – names, geography, history, etc. – is almost absent from other historical records, a fact which led to many speculations by different scholars. Solutions for the problems of the book have been suggested by three groups of researchers: The first considered the book, based upon the uniqueness of the details, to be unrealistic and ideological in nature. The second have identified some reality in the story and dated it to the Hasmonean-Hellenistic period. The third group accepted, like the second one, some degree of reality, but dated it to the Persian period.

A factor common to all the scholars was the lack of archaeological-geographical exploration of the area. The general geography was defined through several identifications: Dothaim-Dothan, Ginei-Jenin, Jezreel, Beth-Horon, Jericho and Bel'ameh-Ibleam. As for others (Bethuliyah, Bethomestaim, Kush, Kuamon, Shalem, Aqrabim, Nahal Mihmor, Kona, Hoba, etc.) no clue has been suggested.

A detailed exploration of the territory, with geographical analysis, leads to the following conclusions:

1. The story is firmly based upon geographical and archaeological reality;
2. New identifications have been suggested for almost all the sites, and above all to Bethuliyah and Beth-Hommotaim. In addition, identifications for the water sources and topography, including "the great pass to Judah" and the assembly area for the Persian army, have now all been proposed.
3. The reality of the story relates well to the Persian period. This suits the 'wave' of settlement of the period found by us and suggested by Grintz (1957: 29–43) to be a part of the return to Zion from Babylon. According to this idea, the Jews returned not only to Jerusalem (as recorded in the books of Ezra and Nehemiah), but also to Samaria. This notion may explain the large settlement and the unique literary source.

4. Hellenistic period

During this period a general decline in habitation occurred in the Samaria hill country, possibly resulting from the major harm inflicted upon the Israelite-Samaritan population by the Macedonian conquest. No historical texts refer specifically to the territory discussed except, probably, the mention of the 'Jews of Arbathah' in I Macc 5: 21–23: "So Simon went to Galilee and fought many battles against the Gentiles, and the Gentiles were crushed before him. He pursued them to the gate of Ptolemais; as many as three

thousand of the Gentiles fell, and he despoiled them. Then he took the Jews of Galilee and Arbatta, with their wives and children, and all they possessed, and led them to Judea with great rejoicing.” (Meeks 1993: 1660).

It has been suggested, based on linguistic and geographic arguments (Klein 1930: 369; Alt 1932: 32, and also Zertal 1984: 133–134), that the form ‘Arbata’ in Greek, referred to the Jewish district in the west of Samaria. An additional vague mention exists in I Macc 9: 2 in the description of Bacchides’s march to the Battle of Elasa: “They went by the road that leads to Gilgal encamped against Mesaloth in Arbela, and they took it and killed many people.” (Meeks 1993: 1670). Awald, followed by Grintz, suggested that Bacchides marched via the spinal plateau of the hills to Shechem and Jerusalem. Messiloth could be Mesalia near the Sanur Valley, and Arbaloth is the Arbatha district. However, the linguistic likeness is not straightforward, and the entire issue is obscure (Bar-Kochva 1980: 157–158 and references therein).

During this period the area was conquered by the Hasmonean kings (Alexander Yannai or previously), who founded the Jewish district of Arbatta/Narbatah. This was a Jewish enclave in an alien Samaritan region, presumably based on a Jewish nucleus existing there since the Persian period. The toparchy founded here served later as a basis of a zealot kernel in the Great Revolt which was connected to Caesarea’s Jews.

5. Early Roman (Herodian) period

This period is overshadowed by the main event – the beginning of the Great Revolt in spring-autumn 66 CE. The previous identification of Josephus’ Narbatah as Kh. Beidus (Site 93), suggested by Mazar (Maisler 1934: 97), was inconclusive, because it was impossible to fit it into an archaeological context. The discovery of the siege works at Kh. el-Ḥamam, and the suggestion of identifying it with Arubboth-Narbatah, has created a new basis for the discussion.

Narbatah is mentioned twice by Josephus as a focus of zealot activity. His first account, dealing with the flight of zealots from Caesarea to Narbatah during Passover 66 with the Scrolls of the Law (Torah) states:

“On the following day, which was a Sabbath, when the Jews assembled at the synagogue, they found that one of the Caesarean mischief-makers had placed beside the entrance a pot, turned bottom upwards, upon which he was sacrificing birds. This spectacle of what they considered an outrage upon their laws and a desecration of the spot enraged the Jews beyond endur-

ance. The steady-going and peaceable members of the congregation were in favour of immediate recourse to the authorities; but the factious folk and the passionate youth were burning for a fight. The Caesarean party, on their side, stood prepared for action, for they had, by a concerted plan, sent the man on to the mock sacrifice; and so they soon came to blow. Jucundus, the cavalry commander commissioned to intervene, came up, removed the pot and endeavoured to quell the riot, but was unable to cope with the violence of the Caesareans. The Jews, thereupon, snatched up their copy of law and withdrew to Nabata, a Jewish district sixty furlongs distant from Caesarea." (War II, xiv, 5).

The second instance describes Cestius Gallus' cavalry incursion, destroying the district of Nabatah (see below). The identification raises two questions contradicting the description in the text. In both – the distance from Caesarea and the description of the foray – there is some conflict between the narrative and the archaeological finds, as follows:

1. The distance from Caesarea to the possession (*chora*) of the Jews, Nabatah, is 60 furlongs, about 12 km (This is the basis for the previous identification of Kh. Beidus), while the distance to Kh. Ḥamam is double – about 25 km. According to Avi-Yonah's suggestion (1963: 12, 127), if the distances were measured from the toparchy's boundary and not from the city itself, they would correspond to Josephus' account.
2. In War II (xviii, 10), the cavalry foray was described as follows: "Cestius likewise dispatched a strong force of cavalry into the toparchy of Nabatene, which borders on Caesarea; these ravaged the country, killed a large number of the inhabitants, pillaged their property and burnt their villages". There is no mention of a siege or prolonged action. The central city is not mentioned, and the horsemen were sent to the *district* of Nabatah and not to the city itself.

Other scholars (Levine 1974; Kasher 1977; Rappaport 1978; Zertal 1982) analyzed the beginning of the revolt, and emphasized the conflict between zealots and moderates in Caesarea. It was an echo of the general division among the country's Jews on the eve of the Revolt, and its instigator to a certain extent, Josephus, called these events the "beginning of the war". The remote district of Nabatah was a convenient retreat to fortify, and the transfer of the Scrolls of the Law became a religious-national symbol.

Florus, the Roman Procurator, arrested the nobles of Caesarea for removing the Scrolls from the city (War II, xiv, 5). It was an expression of independence by the Jewish district, and a continuation of the Israelite centre of the Persian Book of Judith and the Hellenistic Arbata district.

The city, with the villages around it, was difficult to approach. Therefore, Cestius Gallus sent his cavalry there in the autumn of 66 on his way to Jerusalem to subdue the revolt in its initial stage (War II, xviii, 10). The mopping-up of the rebels' nests, starting at Mount Atzmon in the Lower Galilee, was extended to Jaffa and Narbatah, and secured the rear of the army, and prevented the revolt from spreading swiftly while the bulk of the expeditionary force was assembling in Jerusalem. The incident at Narbatah was similar to those at Mount Atzmon, although at Narbatah and its surrounding villages a mopping-up operation was conducted.

Around Kh. el-Ḥamam (Site 146), a Roman siege system with a circumvallation, camps, and probably a rampart, was revealed. The siege has been dated to the 1st century CE, and matches the story in the written sources. In order to locate Narbatah to fit the historical source, the question is where Narbatah used to be, if Kh. el-Ḥamam is not the correct place; or conversely, what is Kh. el-Ḥamam, if it is not Narbatah?

Firstly, most of the archaeological and geographical evidence indicates Kh. el-Ḥamam to be Arubboth-Narbatah: the preservation of the name Arubboth in 'Arrabeh, the whole array of districts, and the city of Arubboth as part of Manasseh's possession in the hill country; the archaeological finds at the site, the roads and fortifications; and first and foremost – the siege works. During the First Revolt, military activities in Samaria are mentioned only in Narbatah (except for the episode at Mount Gerizim – War III, vii, 32). The archaeological finds at Narbatah point to the city's establishment during the time of the United Monarchy, and also its end in the 1st century CE.

Secondly, although the distance from Caesarea (60 furlongs, about 12 km) matches the source, Kh. Beidus does not fit the identification, as its location is not strategic, it is unsuitable for evasive and escape actions, and there is no evidence of its being a target for attack.

The finds of the Survey in the surrounding area and the date of destruction support the suggested identification. In most of the Early Roman period sites there was no continuation of settlement into the Late Roman period, and it seems that the district's settlements were destroyed in 66 CE. This was also the situation in Kh. el-Ḥamam, according to well-founded data. The fact that the site is not mentioned in sources after the Great Revolt also helps.

The boundary of the possibly Jewish-inhabited toparchy of Narbatah may be suggested as follows: it reached 'Illar in the west, where the burial inscription of Manasseh Ben Yannai has been found, and Faḥmeh in the

south-east, where a carved door with a Holy Ark was found. The village of Othnai (Kafir Dan?) serves in the sources both as the boundary between the Galilee and Samaria, and a place of Cutheans.

6. Late Roman and Byzantine periods

In these periods the region disappeared from the historical scene, and was seldom mentioned. It seems that in the Great Revolt the Jewish population of the district of Nabatah ceased to exist, while a mixed population of Samaritans and pagans took its place. The role of Samaria in the Bar-Kokhba Revolt was insignificant, as its Samaritan inhabitants took little part in it. Most of the Samaritan settlements were located in the central Samaria hill country and on the Sharon coast, and there were few in this area.

The Samaritan ring, with fragmented verses of the Torah, found in Kh. Qusiyeh which is next to Baqa el-Garbiyeh, and identified as 'Ein Kushi (Zertal 1977) – was instrumental in the identification of Samaritan settlements as "Cuthaen towns near the road" (Tosefta Demai 85: 529). In the Jewish sources Samaria is called a "patch of Cutheans", and there are a few mentions in the Mishna and Talmud.

Gafni (1971) counts several Samaritan settlements, among them Kfar Othnai (Kafir Dan or Kafir Kod). The extent of settlements described in the Rehov inscription, an important source from the 6th century CE, proves again that there were few Samaritan settlements in the region. The Samaritan settlements here were Zeitah in the south-west, Bal'ah (*Bal'an*) in the south (about which there are no details in the text), Kafir Dan (Kfar Othnai) in the north-east, and 'Anin in the north. The same conclusion arises from Ben-Zvi's list and the map included in his book (Ben-Zvi 1976: 63).

Only two sites mentioned in the Rehov inscription belong to this region: Kafir Dan, and possibly 'Anin. The nearest settlements (the 'permitted places' – see Sussmann 1981: 165–167) in Samaritan territory are Bal'am Alaitah (Ibleam) and Dothan.

In Nahal 'Iron there is only a single site – 'Anin (see discussion of Site 20). The term 'permitted places' probably relies on the verse in the Jerusalem Talmud Sheviit 6, 36: 73: "Rabbi Abbahu said: There are Samaritan places permitted since the days of Joshua bin Nun and they remain permitted." (Guggenheimer 2001: 503).

It seems as if the region had lost its earlier greatness in the periods discussed, resulting from the urbanized concentration around Caesarea,

Sebastiyeh, and Neapolis. In the Onomasticon (Taylor 2003), there are 11 settlements, mainly in the north of the district, close to Nahal 'Iron and Ta'anach. We suggest Beth Hinei to be identified with Qaşr 'Ein esh-Sheri'ah; Ianoua, to be identified at 'Anin, and Shalem, probably identified with Kafr Salem. In the landscape units of the Jezreel fringes Ta'anach is mentioned twice, Beth Hagan (Ginei/Jenin) once, and Gath-Rimmon twice. Apart from these, Beth 'Eqed Haro'yim (probably the village of Beth Qad) and Socoh, now Kh. Shuweiket er-Ras, also appear. The Onomasticon does not mention sites in the hills of Ya'bad or in the Narbatah district, most of the territory included in this Volume.

We can not suggest identifications of the large sites at Kh. Beit Sama, Kh. Massin, and Kh. Umm er-Riḥan.

7. *Early Moslem, Medieval and Ottoman periods*

Similarly to the rest of the country, there are some sources for the territory from the Early Moslem and Medieval periods, while the Ottoman one is better documented.

In the Early Moslem period (634–1099 CE) the territory was split between the districts of Jund el-Urdun (a small part in the east of the territory) and Jund Filastin (most of the territory). After Caesarea's decline there is almost no mention of this part of Samaria in the sources, and the various travellers mostly describe the coastal towns (Gil 1981: 74). The Moslem geographers, such as el-Maqrizy and el-Mukadasi, do not deal in detail with the settlements in the region.

The historical sources dealing with the districts of Caesarea and Shechem at the time of the Crusades were assembled mainly by Beyer (1936; 1940). Caesarea regained its importance, and most of the villages in the territory are mentioned as her estates (*casales*). Some belonged to the Christian Orders of Jerusalem, and most of them were in the region of Caesarea. Next to the estates, there were several fortresses (*castra*): 'Ar'arah (*Castellum Araerum*), Jenin (*Geninum*), and Ta'anach (*Taanoc*). The boundary between Caesarea and Shechem crossed the area from Kafr Ra'y to Lejjun. Beyer counts 19 villages within the district of Caesarea, included in the Survey area (east of road A1), and 34 more within the district of Shechem.

Northern Samaria played a role during the period of the campaigns between the Moslems and the Crusaders. In 1184, on the eve of the decisive battle against the Crusader Kingdom, Saladin el-Ayyubi conducted an expedition against Karak (Qir Moab) in Jordan. Upon his return, he passed

through Samaria and burnt 'Arrabeh and Jenin. After the defeat of the Crusaders at the Battle of Hittin, one of the Moslem forces under the command of Husam ed-Din Muhammad ibn Lajin passed through Samaria and Nablus. The retreat of the Crusaders initiated a new settlement expansion of tribes belonging to the clan of Yaman (mainly from the family of Bakr Ibn-Va'al and the tribes of the Turabay) between Shechem and Beth Shean. An important source of the period is the list of estates donated by the Mamluk Sultan el-Malek ez-Zaher Baibars (1260–1277 CE) to his loyal Emirs. This list, processed by Abel (1939), Lyons (1971) and others, is dated to the conquest of Caesarea and Arsuf (Apollonia) in March-April 1265, and lists the estates of the Crusaders and the villages in the district of Caesarea. Ibn Halikan, Baibars' scribe, recorded the name of each Emir and the size of the estate he was due to receive according to his appointment and the role he played in the war. Some of the village names were distorted in copying, but all can be identified. Of the 36 villages listed, 18 belong to the territory included in this Volume. Of these 13th century villages, only two (Ferasin and Tubras) do not exist today, evidence of the stability of the settlement in the region.

The Mamluk Sultan Ibn Qalaun (1293–1294, 1298–1308, and 1309–1340 CE) initiated administrative reform, but left the district (*amal*) of Shechem unchanged. He encouraged the settlement of the Qis and Yaman clans, thus starting a bloody tradition of disputes between them. Generally, the Qis clan supported the regime, while the Yaman opposed it. In 1486, one of the major conflicts between these clans broke out. It ended in conciliation between the clan of Qis and the Mamluk authorities and the slaying of Emir Aqbardy el Ainally (Yekutieli 1971: 209).

An important source for the period following the Ottoman conquest at the beginning of the 16th century was the general census of 1596, published by Hütteroth and 'Abdulfattah (1977). It is the first record of its kind of all the towns, villages and Bedouin tribes, containing much information about the region's economy and the Ottoman administrative division, which was similar to that of the Mamluks. In the Nablus district were four *nahias* (sub-districts): *nahia* Jabl Shami, containing eight villages: Kh. Burin, 'Illar, 'Attil, Baqa el-Gharbiyeh, Bal'a, 'Arrabeh, Faḥmeh, and Ṣaida; *nahia* Jebel Qubal; *nahia* Jebel Qaqun containing Kafr Ra'y, Zeita, Shuweikeh, and Afrassin; and *nahia* Bani Saeb. In *nahia* Sa'ra in the Lajjun district were listed the villages of Baqa esh-Sharqiyeh, 'Ar'arah, 'Anin, Zabebdah, Kafr Adan, Rummaneh, Ta'aniq, Kh. Ṭaiybeh, Umm el-Faḥm, Jenin, el-Yamun, and Qaffin.

Taxation depended upon agricultural productivity, and more than half

of the taxes were paid for growing wheat. The rest was paid for olive trees, goats, honey, summer crops, oil-presses, and *jizyeh* (the poll tax imposed on non-Moslems). The Ottoman census is again evidence of the stability of the population, although most of the villages were very small, only three to ten families each.

Under the Ottoman rule the families of Jarar and Abed el-Hadi, who arrived from Balkah in 1669, lived north of Nahal Shechem in Jenin, 'Arrabeh, and Balad Khartiyeh. The Turabay family (possibly of Turkish origin) joined the forces of the Ottoman Sultan, Sellim I (1512–1520) in 1516, and after the war received the *sanjaq* (district) of Lajjun. The Turabay family was among the strongest in northern Samaria and the Jezreel Valley, and its members held various administrative positions.

The Turabay clan frequently revolted against the Ottoman regime in the 16th century. A prohibition against selling "arrows, bows, horseshoes, nails, food and clothes" to the rebellious Turabay is mentioned in 1552 (Heyd 1960: 95). One of the Turabay leaders, Assef-Bey, was for many years the governor of *sanjaq* Lajjun, and was responsible for a large section of the Damascus–Cairo road (Heyd 1960: 45). In 1579 he received an order to oppose Persian invasion with his army, and immediately afterwards asked to become the ruler of *sanjaq* Nablus, promising that if his requests were met: "...will become responsible for the road up to the boundaries of *sanjaq* Gaza and Jerusalem, and will secure the property and lives of the travellers. He will also collect the public taxes, including the arrears of ten years back (both of the peasants and the tax collectors), and will be in charge of the public security. In addition, he will be willing to build on his account a fortified tower in Khan el-Aḥmar ('the Red Caravanserai') situated between Qaqun and Jaljulia. If there will be ten fortress soldiers, twenty at the fort and mounted musketeers from the citadel of Ras el-Ein (Apheq), the roads will be secured, especially the one to Egypt" (*firman* 61 – Heyd 1960: 109–110). In the *firman* of June 5, 1579 (instructions to *daftarddar* Damascus) the limits of his responsibility for this road were defined to be from Quneitra in the Golan Heights to the boundary of *sanjaq* Nablus.

The Turabay family encountered the Druze Emir Fahr ed-Din II, who extended his rule over the Galilee and Samaria in the first quarter of the 17th century. The disputed areas were in the Galilee, Samaria, and the coastal plain. Fahr ed-Din was exiled to Italy, and returned in 1618 to fight Ahmed ibn-Turabay, who defeated him in 1622–1623. An interesting source concerning the Turabay clan is found in the description by the Turkish traveller Evlia Tshelebi, who visited the region in 1648–1650. After learn-

ing the reasons for their privileges (being with Sellim I at the conquest of the land) Tshelebi wrote: "Because their [the Terabi people, A.Z.] country is rocky and thickly wooded, their nature is secretive. They number about twenty thousand musketeers, including cavalry men on *kuheilan* breed horses. Their houses, built of mud and lime, number seven hundred. There is a Friday mosque and other small mosques as well as tiny shops, gardens, and orchards. The climate is extremely agreeable. I was their guest for a night. The sheikh-emir presented the humble writer with a horse, fifty piasters, and a striped *kereke*.

Accompanied by fifty armed mounted beduins we went for five hours in a southerly direction, then for another hour through the valley of Jinin [the Dothan Valley, A.Z.], passed the village of *Qabatye* and arrived at '*Arrabe*. It consists of a hundred Moslem houses and [its revenue] is set aside for the pasha, who is governor of Nablus." (Stephan 1938: 88).

In 1670 a serious rebellion broke out in Balqa (Jordan), and as a result many inhabitants moved to northern Samaria. The 18th century was overshadowed by Daher el-Omar, whose name is associated with the uprising against Ottoman rule in Shechem's hill country. In the preparations for the uprising, reaching its climax in 1774, the fortresses of Jenin, 'Arrabeh, Umm



23. Charcoal makers near Ya'bad, 1991. The tradition of charcoal-making has been rooted in the region for centuries.

el-Faḥm, and Baqa el-Gharbiyeh were built. Apart from the brief uniting of forces against Napoleon Bonaparte in 1799, the unrest in the Shechem hill country (and in our region) continued unceasingly. The main battle against Bonaparte (the Battle of Qaqun) took place near Zeita and Deir el-Ghuṣun (Gichon 1994), when a considerable force of villagers attacked the French column led by General Lannes. The battle, fought to Bonaparte's displeasure, despite being won by the French, inflicted substantial casualties on the villagers and the French.

Reference to the participation by inhabitants of Zeita and Deir el-Ghuṣun in the struggle against the Egyptian army in 1834 appears in Robinson (1970, II: 302). The 19th century witnessed numerous uprisings by the inhabitants of Shechem against the Ottoman rule, but the inhabitants of the north (Nahal 'Iron) and west (Narbatah district) took little part.

CHAPTER TWO

GEOGRAPHICAL-HISTORICAL IDENTIFICATIONS

The area surveyed between Nahal 'Iron and Nahal Shechem yielded new geographical identifications, invaluable for the understanding of the territory and its history. The information comes from the Bible, the Deuterocanonic books, sources from the Second Temple period (especially Josephus, Eusebius, and the Mishna), and Medieval and Ottoman sources.

Sites 6 and 8: Salem (village and tell)

In both sites, being close together, there is considerable presence of sherds from the Iron Age II and Persian periods. Guérin (1969b: 230–232), suggested identifying the place as Shalem in the Book of Judith (4: 4), mentioned in the list of Jewish settlements in Samaria. The difficulty with this list is in its vague substance: is it a mere list, does it define the boundaries of the Jewish settlement at any time, and if so, when? It may be assumed that the limits of the Jewish settlement, when Samaria enjoyed a semi-autonomous standing, appear in it. The area covered by the list includes Beth Horon, Jericho, Asher (perhaps Tayasir, see discussion in Zertal 2008a: 107), and the Shalem Valley. From the above the identification of Shalem with Salem may be suggested, and the Shalem Valley can be one of the nearby small valleys in the border area between the Jezreel Valley and the foot of the Umm el-Faḥm range. In general, there are only a few identifications resulting from the list, and the fact that the word 'Shalem' appears in many site names, such as Jerusalem, is problematic (see in this respect Grintz's discussion 1957: 102).

Additional Bibliography: Grintz 1957: 30, 34, 102; Aḥituv 1976; Moore 1985: 149; Safrai 1987: 169; Handy 1992.

Site 12: Rummaneh

A possible identification with Gath-Rimmon (Josh 21: 25), Haddad-Rimon (Zach 12: 11) and Talmudic Rimon, can be suggested.

1. Gath-Rimmon: a town in the territory of Manasseh on the west side of the Jordan, close to Ta'anach, one of the towns of the Levites, sons of Kohath: "And out of the half tribe of Manasseh, Ta'anach with her suburbs, and Gath-Rimmon with her suburbs; two cities." (Josh 21: 25)

Mazar (1978: 573–574) supports the identification of Gath-Rimmon

with Rummaneh. This place is mentioned in a valley together with Shunem, and we are inclined to identify it in Kh. Yannun (Site 42), some 3 km from Rummaneh.

2. Hadadrimmon is mentioned only in Zach 12: 11: "In that day shall there be a great mourning in Jerusalem, as the mourning of Hadadrimmon in the valley of Megidon". According to Hieronymus, Hadadrimmon was the previous name of Maximianopolis, Legio's Byzantine name, next to Megiddo. It is not obvious whether Hadad-Rimmon is the name of a place or of a god, or perhaps a cult site, as suggested by Mazar (1980a: 256, note 29). He suggests the possibility that Hadadrimmon was a temple to Aram's god Hadad, near the capital of the Assyrian province of Megiddo (Greenfield 1993).
3. Rimmon in the Talmud (see references in Klein 1939: 153): The identification in Rummaneh has been suggested by Avi-Yonah (1976: 91), and suits the geographical data. In Klein's opinion (1939: 153), its location is in the lower Galilee, but there is no evidence for this.

Additional Bibliography: Abel 1967: 24; Kalai 1967: 398–399; Moran 1987: 597.

Site 13: Tell 'Arah

Tell 'Arah is identified with 'Arunah. In Thutmosis III's memoirs of his first expedition (c. 1485 BCE) 'Arunah is mentioned as the place of the army's assembly facing the passage through Nahal 'Iron before the Battle of Megiddo. The battle was fought against the Canaanite coalition led by the King of Qadesh on the Orontes. 'Arunah is mentioned twice (no. 27, ANET: 235–236), and once in Shishak's list on the southern wall of the temple at Karnak (ANET: 242). This name (no. 32) comes after Megiddo (no. 27), the King's Memorial (no. 29 – which could have been a royal memorial at the entrance to the wadi), and Hinam (no. 31). After 'Arunah comes Burim (no. 33), probably Burin in Baqa el-Gharbiyeh, see Site 129 in this Volume. The archaeological finds and the location permit the identification of 'Arunah as Tell 'Arah.

The suggestion of Noth of identifying 'Arah according to Josh 13: 3–4 should be considered: "From Sihor which is before Egypt, even unto the borders of Ekron northward, which is counted to the Canaanite: five lords of the Philistines; the Gazathites, and the Ashdothites, the Ashkalonites, the Gittites, and the Ekronites; also the Avites: From the south, all the land of the Canaanites, and from 'Arah that is beside the Sidonians, unto Aphek, to the

borders of the Amorites.” This is a part of the description of the remainder of the land which the Israelites did not inherit. The problem is in ascribing ‘Arunah (translated as ‘Arah) to the Sidonians, which is difficult to justify. ‘Arunah is situated inland, and there is no obvious relationship with the coastal plain. There is no proof for such a deep Phoenician penetration, and therefore Noth’s opinion should remain a hypothesis.

Additional Bibliography: ANET: 235–236, 242; Albright 1923: 11; Simons 1937: 89ff, 178ff; Abel 1951: 49–51; Helck 1962: 123–125; Abel 1967: 24; Aharoni 1979: 49–52, 153–158, 323–325; Kitchen 1973: 432–447; Mazar 1980c: 239.

Site 17: Kh. et-Ṭaiybeh

The identification suggested by Gal (1980: 69) is Ophrah of the Abi-Ezrites (Judg 6: 24). It relies upon two assumptions: firstly, that Issachar settled together with Manasseh in the north of Samaria; and secondly, that the name Ṭaiybeh retains within it the form ‘*apher*’ (Arabic: demon, mischievous power). This was proposed by Alt (1925a: 30; 1925b: 109–110; 1928: 13ff, 32ff), and since then there have been attempts to identify both of the Ṭaiybehs with the expressions *apher* and *ophrah*.

The proposition is difficult to accept for two reasons: firstly, no Iron Age sherds have been found in the village; and secondly, Ophrah should be in the Abiezer district. We are of the opinion that the place is west of Sebastiyeh, because of the linguistic similarity of the names Abiezer and Bazariyeh, first suggested by Dussaud (1926: 10). We suggest identifying the town of Abiezer at es-Sirtassa near Homesh and Bazariyeh (Zertal 2004: 76; site 137). Acceptance of Gal’s proposition means expansion of the district of Abiezer further north into the territory of Manasseh, which has no factual support.

Site 20: ‘Anin

The identification proposed is with Aniam, son of Shemidah, one of Manasseh’s families (I Chr 7: 19): “The sons of Shemidah were Ahian, Shechem, Likhi, and Aniam”. Two opinions are put forward for the interpretation of the name: from the Arabic word *en’am* (Gray 1896: 44), or from the word ‘*ani* (the) *am*’ according to the Akkadian words ‘*anaku iluma*’ (Mazar in Loewenstamm 1950: 459). Noth (1928: 237, no. 192) is of the opinion that this is a distortion of the name ‘*No‘ah*’, one of Zelophehad’s daughters (Num 26: 33). If indeed this is so, then the village of ‘Anin relates to Noah’s possession in the north-east of Samaria. Lemaire and Zertal have proposed